

THE HUNTSMAN

TV PILOT

Written by

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Based on the novel The Huntsman by Christopher Bye,
writing as DH Austin

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FADE IN:

EXT. OUTER SPACE - ANDROMEDA GALACTIC RIM - DAY

The void at the galaxy's edge -- a chaotic maelstrom of cosmic debris. Massive stellar winds drive dense clouds of micrometeorites at lethal velocities.

Violent electrical storms crackle in the distance, arcs of plasma slicing through darkness. This is the galaxy's deadliest frontier.

SUPER: "THE GALACTIC RIM - DESIGNATION: EXTREME HAZARD ZONE"

THE HUNTSMAN, a sleek chrome sphere with a central rotating disc, navigates this hellscape alone. Its scarred hull bears the marks of countless past impacts.

Ahead looms THE WANDERER ASTEROID -- massive, ancient, coal-black with pulsing blue crystalline veins reacting to the storms. Steam vents from its craggy surface.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The bridge operates with calm efficiency. CAPTAIN NICO MINARDI, (45, Dark hair olive skin, weathered face bearing the weight of command) stands at the bridge in the crisp blue-gray uniform of the Unity Fleet, insignia gleaming on his collar.

Stands beside COMMANDER BELLE CASPARI-MINARDI (43, auburn hair, pale complexion, sharp intellect evident in her focused gaze, carries herself with scientific precision) at the main viewscreen. The Milky Way galaxy dominates the display -- a spiral of light against the cosmic void.

BELLE

(awed, touching the screen)
Min, I can't believe how beautiful
that galaxy looks. One day they'll
merge together in a cosmic dance over
billions of years.

MINARDI

(studying her face, gentle)
You always see the poetry in
everything, even in the most hostile
places.

BELLE

(turning to him, eyes bright)
That's why we're perfect together. You
keep me grounded, I keep you dreaming.

They share a moment of quiet
connection. Belle's hand finds his.

BELLE (CONT'D)

(reluctant to break the spell)
I should head to the lab. The
extraction won't prep itself.

A SHUDDER courses through the ship as
they begin to enter a debris field

MINARDI

(squeezing her hand)
I guess that was your cue. She kisses
his cheek -- tender, inadvertently
final.

BELLE (CONT'D)

See you on the other side of this
rock.

As Belle exits, Minardi watches her go, unaware this peaceful
moment will be their last for months.

The ship SHUDDERS again. Warning lights begin to flash. The
storm is building.

MINARDI

(into comm, all business now)
All stations, we're entering the
hazard zone. Thirty minutes to get in,
grab the sample, and get out.

ACT ONE

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - DAY

The bridge buzzes with tension. CAPTAIN MINARDI grips his command chair as the ship shudders from micrometeorite hits. Warning lights flash across displays.

At the helm, twins LIEUTENANT MILO CHEN (24, East Asian features, male twin with an analytical mind, slight build but intense concentration) and LIEUTENANT NISO CHEN (24, East Asian features, female twin with protective instincts, more physically assertive than her brother) coordinate seamlessly.

LIEUTENANT COMMANDER SARAH REEVES (32, dark skin, efficient operations officer with quiet authority) monitors systems at Operations.

MINARDI

(into comm)

We're almost there, team.am. Priority Alpha mission. Thirty minutes to get in, grab the sample, and get out.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

(to Milo)

Shield status?

MILO

Shields at forty-two percent. This debris field is -- (console sparks)
Tearing us apart!

The ship ROCKS violently. Sparks erupt from a console. A ceiling panel crashes down.

NISO

(alarmed)

And it's getting worse. Major plasma storm building to port -- (ship shudders violently) If it hits, we're dust.

REEVES

(studying displays)

Captain, electromagnetic interference from the Wanderer is spiking. The crystalline matrix is reacting to the storms.

MINARDI

(into comm, urgent)

Belle, how much longer until you're
set for extraction?

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - DOCKING BAY/LABORATORY

The docking bay at the ship's lowest deck is transformed into a high-stakes operation zone. The shuttle is gone, replaced by a massive EXTRACTION DRILL dominating half the cavernous space, its sheer size a testament to the mission's ambition.

The drill bit, a towering, reinforced spike, is precisely positioned at the center of the docking bay doors -- designed so the doors only need to open slightly during extraction, allowing the bit to extend and bore into the Wanderer asteroid with minimal exposure.

A clear, REINFORCED BARRIER divides the bay: on one side, the drill and external access; on the other, a makeshift lab shielded from potential hazards.

This barrier acts as a critical shield, preventing oxygen escape from the lab side when the doors crack open for drilling, preserving Belle's environment amidst the vacuum beyond.

COMMANDER BELLE CASPARI-MINARDI (sharp, focused, wearing a full Hazmat suit) stands alone behind the barrier, adjusting scientific equipment with steady hands.

A monitor displays the Wanderer looming closer, its blue crystalline veins pulsing intensely, almost rhythmically. Shadows flicker oddly in the lab despite steady lighting, adding an eerie undertone to her isolation.

BELLE

(into comm, focused)

Min, systems are ready. The drill is positioned, and the lab is prepped for extraction. dy. Drill is positioned, lab prepped for extraction. (checking readings) We can start the moment we're in optimal range.

BELLE (CONT'D)

(slight unease, to herself)

There's something about that asteroid... feels like it's watching us.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

MINARDI

(into comm)

Copy that, Belle. Stay sharp down there. We're feeling it too. Weirdest thing I've ever seen.

REEVES

Captain, EM interference is messing with navigation. We're half-blind out here.

MINARDI

(frustrated)

Acknowledged. Launch a Sentinel probe for navigational support. Shields won't hold another hour at this rate.

MILO

The Wanderer's EM field is intensifying. Almost like it's... responding to us.

Suddenly, a PULSE of blue light flares from the Wanderer on the viewscreen, a subtle energy wave washing over the Huntsman. No explosion yet -- just a precursor. The crew tenses as alarms chirp.

NISO

Captain, energy spike detected! Not critical, but -- Before she finishes, the first vision strikes. The crystalline spores haven't breached yet; this is a subtle effect of the EM pulse, triggering hallucinations one by one over the next few minutes.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Suddenly, a PULSE of blue light flares from the Wanderer on the viewscreen, washing over the Huntsman. Alarms chirp.

MINARDI'S VISION BEGINS

Shadows twist into unnatural patterns as Belle materializes before Minardi, bathed in blue light. Her hand reaches out to cup his cheek, her touch warm yet fleeting. "Min, I need to leave soon," she says, her voice resolute. "I have a calling, something I must answer." Tears well in his eyes as she wipes one away, adding, "It won't be forever; I will return. I love

you," before fading into the shadows, leaving him with the hollow ache of impending loss.

MINARDI'S VISION ENDS

MINARDI

(shaken)

Belle...no!

He SNAPS back, jaw tight.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

(sharp, covering)

Report! What was that pulse?

REEVES

(Studying displays, alarmed)

Captain, the readings are going crazy.

That thing is... (pause, realizing)

It's responding to the storms.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - ENGINEERING BAY - CONTINUOUS

CHIEF SULLIVAN (58, weathered appearance with grey hair and beard, gruff exterior hiding deep loyalty, wears engineering fatigues -- a practical all-in-one boiler suit in Unity Fleet colors with fleet emblem badge) monitors systems when the pulse hits. He FREEZES, eyes wide.

SULLIVAN'S VISION BEGINS

In the dim glow of the engine room, a slick of inky black oil seeps from the shadows, coiling like a system leak straight out of his worst diagnostics nightmare. His breath hitches -- he's an engineer, trained to fix the broken, but this feels alive, whispering of an unstoppable failure that could swallow the ship whole.

SULLIVAN'S VISION ENDS

SULLIVAN

(growling)

What the hell was that

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)

(into comm)

Captain, that pulse hit down here too.

Systems stable, but something's wrong.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

MINARDI

(into comm)

Noted, Sullivan. Stay alert.

WEBBS VISION BEGINS

LIEUTENANT WEBB (38, lean build with sandy hair, thoughtful systems engineer with gentle demeanor, quiet competence masked by unassuming appearance) freezes as faint whispers brush against his ears, more curious than threatening. The sensation fades into a glimpse of a hospital room -- his wife cradling their newborn daughter, smiling as she says, "Say hello to your daughter; she's waiting for you." The vision dissolves, leaving him with quiet resolve and a sense that some paths are meant to be left untaken.

WEBBS VISION ENDS

WEBB

(To himself)

What was that about ?

MILO blinks hard as the vision takes hold.

MILO'S VISION BEGINS

His enhanced savant senses flood with erratic beeps and pulses -- raw, coded signals that twist into a garbled warning of an entity beyond comprehension, like a viral algorithm rewriting reality itself. His eyes glaze over in terror, not from the noise alone, but from the horrifying realization that this code spells out the end of their logical world.

MILO'S VISION ENDS

MILO

(quiet, shaken)

It's not random... it's a signal...

NISO'S VISION BEGINS

Niso feels a sudden chill as shadows slither across the walls like spectral hands reaching out, not for her, but for her twin brother. The shadows twist into echoes of the bullies she's fought off her entire life, protecting Milo since childhood, now morphed into an all-consuming void that threatens to tear them apart. Her heart races with the same protective fury she's always felt, tears welling as she

silently screams, desperate to shield him from this engulfing darkness.

NISO'S VISION ENDS

NISO

(haunted)

Yeah. Something's wrong. I've got you,
always Milo.

MINARDI

(sharp)

Focus, both of you! Reeves, any
updates?

REEVES' VISION BEGINS

The console darkens as her vision blurs into a scene of her two young children reaching out with tear-streaked faces. "Don't go, Mummy, please stay," they sob, their voices echoing with innocent fear. She kneels, wrapping them in a warm embrace, whispering, "I'm not going anywhere; I'll always be here for you."

REEVES' VISION ENDS

REEVES

(alarmed)

Captain, I felt... something. Like
we're being watched.

MINARDI

(grim)

We all did. Whatever's in that
asteroid, it's messing with our heads.
Belle, status?

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - DOCKING BAY/LABORATORY - CONTINUOUS

Belle, behind the reinforced screen, monitors the drill setup. Her vision hits -- last in the sequence.

BELLE'S VISION BEGINS

Belle is suddenly engulfed by swirling shadows that creep from the edges of her vision, accompanied by haunting whispers of an ancient threat. Her hands begin to pulse with blue light, surging through her veins like dormant power awakening. With a commanding voice that echoes through the void, she thrusts her hand forward and declares, "No," the word rippling outward like a shockwave, forcing the shadows

to recoil. Left standing amid the fading echoes, Belle feels a strange, unshakeable purpose blooming within her.

BELLE'S VISION ENDS

BELLE
(whispered, to herself)
It's... calling. Something's out there.

She STUMBLES, clutching the console, snapping back with unease.

BELLE (CONT'D)
(into comm)
Min, I felt it too. That pulse... it's coming from the Wanderer.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

MINARDI
(into comm)
Understood, Belle. I've got a bad feeling about this. I'm going to get The Doctor to you, just in case.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
We're pushing through. Milo, Niso -- get us closer for extraction.

DR ODUYA'S VISION BEGINS

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MEDICAL BAY - CONTINUED

DR. ODUYA (45, medium build with warm brown skin, compassionate healer with steady hands, wears medical division uniform with diagnostic equipment on her belt), grips a counter as dread washes over her. Shadows flicker as ERIN ODUYA, her late husband, materializes in uniform.

DR. ODUYA
Erin... it can't be?

ERIN
Promise me you'll stay at the Station.
That's where you belong.

DR. ODUYA
I'm not planning on going anywhere?

ERIN

Keep it that way. We'll be together
again when the time is right. I love
you.

As he fades, tears roll down her face.

DR. ODUYA

I love you too...

The vision dissipates as the ship's communications system
activates.

DR ODUYA'S VISION ENDS

MINARDI (V.O.)

(into comm, urgent)

Doctor, hazmat suit, docking bay. We
might need you.

She straightens, snapping back to professional mode, her
voice steady despite the lingering emotion.

DR. ODUYA

(into comm)

On my way, Captain. What's the
situation?

MINARDI (V.O.)

(into comm)

Potential hazards during Asteroid core
extraction. We can't take chances --
move fast.

Dr. Oduya grabs a hazmat suit from a nearby locker and heads
for the door, her mind racing with the cryptic warning of the
vision.

FADE OUT

FADE IN

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The bridge lights FLICKER erratically as electromagnetic
waves distort the displays. Alarms pulse softly, casting an
unnatural glow over CAPTAIN MINARDI, who grips the console,
his face tense, eyes scanning the chaotic readouts.

HORUS

(voice crackling, distorted)
Captain... severe interference from
the Wanderer.
(static burst)
Counter-phase fields... deploying now.

MINARDI

Faster, Horus. We can't hold like
this.

HORUS

(voice slowing, fragments)
Tried... magnetic rotation...
shields... hull reversal.
(voice fading)
Emissions... altering us.
Frequencies....

Minardi slams a fist on the panel, urgency etched in his furrowed brow. He watches the shields activate on the screen, but the ship's systems stutter, and the screens glitch with static. The ship's hum deepens into a strained whine.

Navigation holograms warp and fade, revealing fleeting patterns of quantum distortion. Minardi's eyes widen as realization dawns, and he feels a disorienting buzz in his head -- the interference seeping into his thoughts. He straightens, hand hovering over the emergency override.

MINARDI

(voice low, resolute)
Horus, if you falter... I'm taking
control.

A final surge rattles the bridge, dimming the systems further.

HORUS (V.O.)

(voice fading to a whisper)
Affirmative. Maintaining life
support... navigation... as long as I
can.

MILO

(suddenly alert)
Captain! Massive stellar flare
detected from the binary system!
radiation burst incoming!

MINARDI
Time to impact?

NISO
(fighting through her anxiety)
Four minutes, sir! It'll overwhelm our
shields completely!

MINARDI
Emergency manoeuvres! Put the Wanderer
between us and that flare -- use it as
a radiation shield!

The Huntsman manoeuvres to the far side of the asteroid,
shielding it as the stellar flare approaches.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - DOCKING BAY - MAKESHIFT LABORATORY -
CONTINUOUS

Belle works as the robotic drill assembly extends from the
bay and begins extracting a core sample from the Wanderer.
The shadows in the laboratory grow darker and more
oppressive. BELLE (into comm, unease growing) Min, that flare
is supercharging the crystal! The readings are going insane!

MINARDI (V.O.)
(into comm, desperate)
Belle, we have to leave immediately!
Our shields are failing, and Horus is
barely functioning!

Robotic arms extract the violently sparking core sample and
place it on the laboratory table, clamping it down. The
sample pulses with ominous blue light.

BELLE
(into comm)
(staring at the sample, whispered)
It's... beautiful. And terrifying.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Minardi observes the docking bay camera streams from the
Bridge monitors, focusing on the sparking core sample as it
pulses with blinding blue light. Crystalline energy arcs
dancing across its surface. Belle stands motionless,
seemingly mesmerized by the sight.

MINARDI (V.O.)
(screaming into comm)
Belle, get out of there! GET OUT NOW!

Too late. The sample EXPLODES in a cascade of blue crystalline energy, shattering the protective barrier. Belle is thrown against the bulkhead, her biohazard suit visor cracking as she falls headfirst to the floor. Blue crystalline particles swirl through the breached lab as she gasps, inhaling the alien spores.

BELLE
(gasping, inhaling particles)
(into comm)
Emergency... total system failure...

She collapses as the crystalline dust fills her lungs.

A sudden power surge blows out multiple bulkheads. Alarms SCREAM throughout the ship.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

MINARDI
(desperate- into comm)
Dr. Oduya, Belle is down, there's been an explosion. The docking bay is compromised, so you'll have to remain there until we get back.

DR. ODUYA (V.O.)
(into comm)
Understood, Captain, going in now. The bay has medical automatons that should activate immediately and start treating her. There's also an emergency medical stasis pod in there. I'll assess her condition and get her stabilized.

MINARDI
Milo, Niso I need you both to stay focussed. Get the Huntsman away from the Wanderer and out of the hazard zone as soon as Horus and Sullivan confirm sufficient repairs have been completed. I need to check on Commander Belle.

MILO AND NISO
(both now fully attentive)
acknowledged Captain.

Minardi heads for the damaged docking bay.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
(under his breath, anguished)
Damn it, Belle. I should never have
let you go near that thing.

THIRTY MINUTES LATER

HORUS (V.O.)
(clearing, becoming more normal)
Captain, emergency repairs have been
completed and we're at safe distance
from the Wanderer, which has altered
it's trajectory. My processing
capabilities are returning to normal
parameters.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MAKESHIFT LABORATORY/DOCKING BAY - DAY

Dr. Oduya, encased in a bulky contamination suit, moves with
urgent precision alongside whirring medical automatons. They
maneuver Belle's limp form into the glowing emergency stasis
pod, its hum echoing off the metal walls. Through the glass
port window, Minardi lingers at the entry door, his knuckles
white on the frame, face a mask of barely contained
desperation.

The pod seals with a hiss, blue particles flickering across
Belle's skin like faint embers.

DR. ODUYA
(into comm, strained)
She's stable for now, Captain. But
those particles... they're deep in her
system.

Minardi presses closer to the glass, his breath fogging it.
His eyes search hers for hope.

MINARDI
(voice cracking)
And our child?

Dr. Oduya hesitates, her gloved hands freezing on the
controls. Her eyes, visible through the visor, well with
unspoken sorrow -- a pause that says more than words.

DR. ODUYA
(soft, heavy)
I'm sorry.

The weight hits Minardi like a physical blow. He slumps

against the door, whispering to himself.

MINARDI

Hold on, Belle... we're going home.

CUT TO:

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - DOCKING BAY - SECURE CONTAINMENT -
CONTINUOUS

The core sample's remnants pulse faintly in a shielded unit, crystalline fragments shifting like living veins, responding to an invisible rhythm. The blue light casts eerie shadows on the walls, hinting at secrets yet to unravel.

EXT. SPACE - THE HUNTSMAN

The scarred warship begins its journey away from the Galactic Rim, leaving the Wanderer asteroid behind as it continues its journey through the void.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT ONE

FADE IN

ACT TWO

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - DOCKING BAY 7 - DAY

The docking bay CLANGS with industrial noise -- cargo loaders, hissing hydraulics, workers in oil-stained coveralls. The Huntsman's ramp drops with a metallic SCREECH, releasing steam and the crew into harsh fluorescent lighting. CAPTAIN NICO MINARDI staggers out first, uniform torn and singed. Behind him, LIEUTENANT MILO and NISO CHEN support each other, faces streaked with soot.

CHIEF SULLIVAN limps down, tools still rattling on his belt. A MEDICAL TEAM in grimy white coats rushes through puddles of coolant and debris, their equipment jury-rigged and battle-tested. MEDIC TORRES (shouting over machinery noise) Where's the critical? We got the alert!

MEDIC TORRES (40s, Hispanic features, weathered hands that speak of field experience, emergency medical patches on her coat) coordinates the team's response. Minardi points as DR. ODUYA guides Belle's stasis pod down the ramp -- monitors beeping erratically, blue particles still flickering on the cracked visor like deadly snow.

DR. ODUYA (urgent, professional) Alien spore contamination. Neural infiltration. She's stable but get her to ICU Now.

The medics lock the pod onto a battered gurney, wheels squeaking as they roll toward the exit. Minardi reaches out but pulls back, his hand trembling.

Sullivan grips his shoulder -- two soldiers who've seen too much. The Huntsman looms behind them, scarred and smoking, a wounded predator in its steel nest.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL ICU

CAPTAIN MINARDI takes one final glance at BELLE in her stasis chamber, staff busily making adjustments and monitoring before exiting the room.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL CORRIDOR - DAY

CAPTAIN MINARDI walks through sterile white corridors, head down, lost in thought. The clinical lighting casts harsh shadows. His footsteps echo off polished floors as he passes

medical equipment and uniformed personnel.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - TRANSITIONAL CORRIDOR -
CONTINUOUS

The pristine medical environment gradually gives way to industrial utility. White walls become reinforced metal plating. Fluorescent lighting flickers and dims, replaced by amber work lights. Steam hisses from overhead conduits.

Minardi's pace remains steady, but his shoulders carry visible weight.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - INDUSTRIAL CORRIDOR -
CONTINUOUS

The transformation complete -- exposed pipes, warning signs, the distant hum of machinery. Minardi's boots CLANG against metal grating. He passes MAINTENANCE WORKERS in coveralls, their conversations muffled by the ambient noise.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - DOCKING BAY 7 - CONTINUOUS

The bay erupts with activity. Welding sparks shower from overhead repairs. Heavy CARGO LOADERS rumble past. The familiar chaos of a working spaceport -- but now it feels like sanctuary.

Minardi approaches The Huntsman's boarding ramp, his pace quickening slightly. Home.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - ENGINEERING BAY - DAY

CHIEF SULLIVAN (58, gruff) looks up from his workbench as Minardi enters. Tools and schematics scattered around him, but his attention immediately shifts to his captain's expression.

SULLIVAN

(setting down his tools)

You look like hell, Captain. How'd it go?

Minardi slumps into a nearby chair, running a hand through his hair.

MINARDI

The visions won't stop for her, Sully.
What we felt for a few minutes...
she's living it every second. They're
using some sort of resonance field to
(MORE)

MINARDI (CONT'D)
nullify the effects. She should be
kept comfortable... a bit like stasis
in the early colonization days.

Sullivan moves to a cabinet, retrieving a bottle of whiskey
and two glasses.

SULLIVAN
So she's staying in stasis for now?
Until they find a long-term solution?

MINARDI
(nodding heavily)
That's the plan.

Sullivan pours two generous measures, sliding one across to
Minardi.

SULLIVAN
Could be worse news, Min. At least
she's stable. And if anyone can figure
this out, it's the eggheads upstairs.

MINARDI
(staring at his glass)
I saw the scans, Sully. Those blue
things... they're everywhere now.
Growing, spreading... (voice breaking
slightly) What if we can't bring her
back?

Sullivan sits across from him, his weathered face showing
rare gentleness.

SULLIVAN
Hey. This is Belle we're talking
about. She survived the Wanderer,
survived the explosion, survived
things that would've killed anyone
else. She's not giving up now.

MINARDI
(taking a sip)
Weaver thinks they're trying to
communicate. That Belle isn't just
seeing things... she's learning
something..

SULLIVAN
(leaning back)
Well, that's either terrifying or
fascinating. Knowing Belle, probably
both.

A moment of comfortable silence. The ship's familiar hum
surrounds them -- a mechanical lullaby that speaks of home
and continuity.

MINARDI
It's interesting in my vision on the
Wanderer, Belle appeared just before
the explosion. She mentioned having a
calling, something she needed to
answer.
(a beat)
Anyway thanks, Sully. For listening.
For... this.
(gestures to the whiskey)

SULLIVAN
(raising his glass)
To Belle. And to bringing her home.

They drink, two old friends sharing the weight of uncertainty
in the belly of their beloved ship.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "ONE MONTH INTO STASIS"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - ADMINISTRATIVE CORRIDOR - DAY.

CAPTAIN MINARDI walks alongside ADMIRAL REDBACK through
polished corridors. The environment is formal -- gleaming
surfaces, proper lighting, official portraits lining the
walls. Very different from the industrial chaos of the
docking bays.

MINARDI
(suspicious)
What are we doing here, Admiral? This
isn't exactly your usual stomping
ground.

REDBACK
(walking briskly)
Just trust me, Min. You need to see
this. They pass CADETS in crisp
(MORE)

REDBACK (CONT'D)
uniforms, heading to classes. The
sound of military instruction echoes
from nearby training rooms.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - ELEVATOR - CONTINUOUS

The elevator doors close. Minardi immediately hits the
EMERGENCY STOP button. The elevator lurches to a halt.

MINARDI
(intense)
Belle isn't getting any better. I need
to know everything you knew before we
set off for the Wanderer -- or
whatever the hell it was.

Redback meets his gaze steadily, but there's discomfort in
the confined space.

REDBACK
Min, I told you --

MINARDI
(interrupting)
No more runarounds. No more fragments.
Is it some weapon? Alien technology?
What are they planning to do with it?

REDBACK
(carefully)
The sample we recovered... It's unlike
anything previously discovered.
There's even speculation that it may
not be from this universe.

MINARDI
(voice breaking slightly)
Will she recover? Will Belle ever be
Belle again?

REDBACK
(softening)
I don't know, Min. But she'll need you
whole when she wakes, and I believe
she will. Right now, you're running on
fumes.

She reaches for the elevator controls, but Minardi doesn't
move aside.

REDBACK (CONT'D)

I've told you everything I know. Look, you can't just sit around the med lab all day. The station academy needs an instructor for advanced tactics and command. That's why I brought you here to have a look around. You'd also stay near Belle, and you'd have a purpose.

MINARDI

I appreciate it, but --

REDBACK

It's not a handout. These recruits need a battle-tested leader -- someone who's lived through combat.

A heavy silence. The elevator's emergency lighting casts stark shadows.

MINARDI

(releasing the stop button)

When do I start? The elevator resumes its ascent with a mechanical whisper.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "TWO MONTHS INTO STASIS"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - STASIS FACILITY - MEDICAL CHAMBER - NIGHT

Soft blue light glows from the stasis pod. MINARDI sits beside BELLE, reading one of her old fairy tale books quietly. His voice is gentle, steady -- a lifeline in the hush of the chamber.

MINARDI

(reading, barely above a whisper)

...and so, even in the darkest night,
the stars remember their names...

He glances at Belle's face, searching for any sign of recognition. Her eyes are closed, but beneath the lids, they flicker -- rapid, restless.

The camera slowly pushes in, leaving Minardi's world behind, moving closer to Belle's face, the blue glow deepening. Her eyelids tremble. The hum of the monitors fades, replaced by a

distant, melodic wind.

FADE TO:

BELLE'S VISION - BEGINS

EXT. OTHERWORLDLY GARDEN - NIGHT

An open-air classroom beneath a sky ablaze with stars -- a luminous band like the Milky Way arcs overhead, comets streaking silently across the heavens. The air shimmers with possibility. Children of many species sit in a semi-circle, eyes wide with wonder. At the front stands THE ELDER -- a tall, slender alien with pure blue skin, draped in silver robes. Holographic threads of gold and silver swirl between his hands, forming a great, radiant spider at the center of a cosmic web.

BELLE stands at the back, translucent, dreamlike, taking in the scene.

THE ELDER

(gentle, storytelling)

Long ago, the Ancient Star Weavers
spun the stars into the sky, weaving
each thread with care. Where their web
touched, life blossomed -- planets,
people, dreams...

The children watch as the holographic golden spider weaves a glowing web across the night sky. Suddenly, a shadow creeps in -- a dark, spindly spider, silent and hungry, it begins to devour the golden threads.

THE ELDER (CONT'D)

(lower, a hint of warning)

But in every story, there is a shadow.
The Dark Spider crept in, hungry for
the light, and began to eat the
threads, one by one...

The children shiver, but the Elder smiles, reassuring.

THE ELDER (CONT'D)

(hopeful)

But the Star Weavers were not alone.
The Blue Angel, born of Crystal
starlight, danced across the web,
mending what was broken, bringing hope
wherever she went...

The hologram shows a tiny blue figure -- delicate, luminous -- flitting between the broken threads, weaving them anew. The children sigh in relief, enchanted. Belle, at the back, feels a pull -- she looks down, and her own hands glow faint blue, echoing the fairy's light. Suddenly, the vision blurs. The comets above swirl into a funnel, and Belle is swept up, becoming one of them, racing through the cosmos toward a distant, blinding light --

BELLE'S VISION - ENDS

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL CHAMBER - NIGHT

The monitors beep rapidly. Belle's eyelids flutter, but do not open. The blue glow pulses erratically.

MINARDI, alarmed, runs to the door shouting towards a Doctor walking down the corridor.

MINARDI

Please help, I'm not sure what's going on?

A DOCTOR checks the readings, then offers a reassuring nod.

DOCTOR

Everything seems fine. She was dreaming. That's a good sign -- her brain's more active. It means she's fighting her way back.

Minardi lets out a shaky breath, hope flickering in his eyes as the blue light steadies and the chamber quiets.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "THREE MONTHS INTO STASIS"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - DOCKING BAY 7 - TRAINING AREA - DAY

The cavernous docking bay ECHOES with industrial noise -- hydraulic lifts, welding torches, and the clang of metal on metal. Overhead cranes move cargo containers while steam hisses from cooling vents.

Two training groups work simultaneously on the oil-stained deck plating. GROUP ONE: LIEUTENANT MARA SOLIS (29, bronze complexion, intensity burning behind dark eyes, carries

herself like a fighter) Mara circles young CADETS like a predator. They're practicing weapon assembly, hands shaking under her glare.

MARA

(sharp, impatient)

Faster! The enemy won't wait for you
to figure out which end shoots!

CADET LOPEZ (19) fumbles his rifle components. Mara KICKS his scattered gear across the deck.

MARA (CONT'D)

Again! From the beginning!

The cadets exchange fearful glances, scrambling to comply.

GROUP TWO: LIEUTENANT JACE KELLEN (31, fair-skinned with reddish hair, cocky swagger masking deeper insecurities) demonstrates advanced combat manoeuvres with flashy precision. His cadets watch in awe but struggle to replicate his moves.

JACE

(showing off)

This is how you take down hostiles in
under four seconds.

He executes a brutal combo and spinning kick on a punching bag. The cadets attempt it -- most fail spectacularly. LIEUTENANT COMMANDER ETHAN TANNER (35, dark skin, stoic presence that commands respect without words) leans against a shipping container, arms crossed, saying nothing. The bay's massive blast doors open. CAPTAIN NICO MINARDI enters with his own group of CADETS, mid-demonstration.

MINARDI

(calm, instructive)

Remember, your weapon is only as good
as your confidence in it. Master the
basics first. His cadets work
methodically through the same weapon
assembly. No fear, no rushing -- just
steady competence.

Mara notices, her voice getting louder and more aggressive.

MARA

(to her struggling cadets)

You see that? That's what happens when
you treat war like a classroom

(MORE)

MARA (CONT'D)
exercise! Lopez tries again, drops a
component. Mara steps closer,
intimidating. MARA (CONT'D) In a real
fight, you'd be dead three times over!

Meanwhile, Minardi's cadets complete their assembly smoothly.
One raises her hand.

CADET CHEN
Captain, what if the mechanism jams
under pressure?

MINARDI
(encouraging)
Good question. Show me what you'd do.

She demonstrates a field-strip technique. Minardi nods
approvingly.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
Exactly. Trust your training, not your
panic.

Jace, overhearing, demonstrates an unnecessarily complex
disarm-and-reassemble sequence.

JACE
(loud enough for all to hear)
Or you could do it the way someone
who's actually seen combat would do
it. His cadets look impressed but
confused -- none can replicate it.

Minardi doesn't take the bait. Instead, he moves to Lopez,
who's now near tears.

MINARDI
(quiet, supportive)
Take a breath. Start with what you
know.

Lopez looks up, surprised by the kindness. Minardi guides him
through the assembly -- no pressure, no judgment.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
There. See? You had it all along.

Mara watches this interaction, her expression shifting from
anger to something resembling curiosity. Tanner pushes off
from the container, walking closer to observe Minardi's

teaching style. His posture shows grudging respect. Jace, however, smirks and whispers to a nearby cadet.

JACE

(under his breath)

Wonder how long that soft touch would
last in a real firefight.

The two groups continue training -- one with growing confidence, the other with increasing anxiety. The contrast is stark and visual. Minardi leads his cadets toward the Huntsman's ramp, their movement fluid and disciplined.

The Pardosa trio watches them go. Mara's fists slowly unclench. Tanner nods almost imperceptibly. Jace's smirk falters slightly. The camera lingers on the scattered gear and shaken cadets left behind -- a stark reminder of different leadership philosophies.

The cavernous docking bay hums with activity, the Huntsman warship looming like a battle-scarred titan, its chrome hull patched but proud. Minardi stands before a group of eager CADETS, his uniform crisp, a faint spark of purpose in his tired eyes. CHIEF SULLIVAN (58, gruff, twinkling eyes) emerges from near the boarding ramp, wiping his hands on a rag.

MINARDI Meet Chief Sullivan. He's kept the Huntsman alive through more battles than most of us have seen stars.

SULLIVAN

(grinning)

She's not just a ship -- she's a legend. How many have been aboard a warship that's seen real action? Tentative hands drop when Sullivan clarifies "real action."

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)

Then welcome to your education.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MAIN CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Sullivan runs his hand along the bulkhead. The wall section slides away, revealing complex armor plating underneath.

SULLIVAN

(demonstrating)

Modular armor. Built to adapt mid-mission. He triggers a control. Emergency bulkheads SLAM shut with
(MORE)

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)
lightning speed, then retract.

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)
Breach a section, emergency bulkheads
seal it in 0.3 seconds.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - ENGINEERING DECK - CONTINUOUS

The fusion reactor hums behind exotic alloys and magnetic shielding -- deep, almost musical. Sullivan places his hand on a control panel. The reactor's intensity shifts subtly, responding to his touch.

SULLIVAN The ship's heart. Ten million degrees.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Stations arranged around a central command table. Sullivan activates the main display. Star charts and tactical overlays illuminate the space around them.

SULLIVAN
Eight crew, total control. The display
shows two highlighted positions:
CAPTAIN and SCIENCE OFFICER.

CADET RODRIGUEZ
What's Commander Belle like?

MINARDI
(quiet, reverent)
Brilliant. The finest officer I've
ever served with. Sullivan's fingers
dance across controls. The ship's
systems respond instantly -- lights
dimming, tactical displays shifting,
even the air circulation adjusting.

SULLIVAN
She's why this ship survived the war.
I've got systems tuned to her specs --
tricks even I can't replicate.

CADET MARTINEZ
(hesitant)
Is she still in service?

MINARDI
She's... between assignments. Sullivan
activates a control. A panel slides
(MORE)

MINARDI (CONT'D)

open, revealing a chamber pulsing with faint blue light.

SULLIVAN

In extreme combat, these neural interface chambers link your mind to the ship. He gestures to the chamber. The blue light pulses rhythmically, almost hypnotically.

CADET VEGA

What's it like in combat?

MINARDI

(heavy with experience)

Surreal. You know you're in stasis, but every sense says you're here.

The cadets fall silent, sobered. One young male cadet (17, intense) lingers, his eyes fixed on Minardi with barely contained anger. Sullivan notices.

SULLIVAN

(quietly, to the cadet)

You got something on your mind, son?

The cadet steps aside from the others.

CADET

(voice tight)

My aunt's Mara Solis. Her mum died when your ship destroyed hers. Sullivan's expression shifts -- recognition, then genuine sorrow.

SULLIVAN

(face softening)

I know who your family is. I'm sorry for your loss.

(pauses)

Captain Minardi lost both his parents too. Their ship was destroyed during the war. The cadet looks away, conflicted.

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)

(soft)

War takes from all of us. Doesn't make it right. But it's not as simple as heroes and villains.

The cadet nods, absorbing this. Sullivan gives him a reassuring pat on the shoulder before sending him on his way.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MAIN DINING HALL - EVENING

The Pardosa crew sits at a table, trays of food mostly untouched. The atmosphere is tense but routine. Mara's nephew, the young cadet, picks at his meal, lost in thought. Mara, noticing, nudges him with a half-smile.

MARA

(teasing, but gentle)

What's up with you, little neph? You look like you just saw a ghost.

The cadet hesitates, glancing at the others, then leans in, voice low.

CADET

It's nothing. Just... the tour of the Huntsman.

(pauses, searching for words)

Chief Sullivan pulled me aside after. He knew who I was. We talked about... Auntie. About the war.

The other Pardosa crew members go quiet, listening. Mara's teasing fades, replaced by a guarded curiosity.

MARA

(softening)

What did he say?

CADET

He said he was sorry. Said Minardi lost both his parents in the war, too.

(shrugs)

Said it's not about heroes and villains. Just scars.

Mara absorbs this, her expression hardening for a moment as she spots Minardi walking past in the distance. Their eyes meet -- hers sharp, his wary. Then, almost imperceptibly, Mara's glare softens. She looks back at her nephew, voice quieter, more thoughtful.

MARA

Yeah, kid...

(sighs, almost to herself)

Sullivan's right. Wars leave scars for everybody.

(beat)

Doesn't mean we have to forget. But maybe...

(she trails off, lost in thought)

The nephew nods, the weight of history settling between them. The Pardosa crew sits in silence, the hum of the dining hall around them, each lost in their own memories.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "FOUR MONTHS INTO STASIS"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL FACILITY - LATE AFTERNOON

Belle lies in her stasis pod, the same soft blue glow. Minardi looks healthier, with a cleaner uniform and less haggard appearance. He reads from a thick technical manual, his voice monotone.

MINARDI

The quantum entanglement properties of crystalline matrices demonstrate a forty-seven percent efficiency increase when subjected to controlled electromagnetic pulses of 2.3 terahertz frequency...

He pauses, glances at Belle's unchanged monitors, then continues reading.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

Furthermore, the lattice structure exhibits nonlinear behavioural patterns that suggest --

(stops, closes book)

You know what, Belle? Even I'm bored by this one.

The door slides open. MILO and NISO enter with DATA PADS, looking determined.

NISO

Captain, we need to talk.

MILO
It's an intervention.

MINARDI
(suspicious)
What kind of intervention?

NISO
The kind where we tell you that you've
been reading scientific journals to
Commander Belle for months on end.

Milo holds up a data pad with detailed charts, graphs, and
timelines.

MILO
I've been tracking this: 847 hours, 23
minutes of continuous technical
exposition.
(shows the pad to Niso)
That's broken down into 312 hours of
quantum mechanics, 198 hours of
crystalline structure analysis, and
337 hours of theoretical physics.

NISO
(looking at the chart)
You actually made a pie chart of our
Captain's grief habits?

MILO
(defensive)
Data visualization helps process
emotional complexity.

NISO
Basically, what he's saying is you've
been boring her unconscious.

MILO
She's already unconscious.

NISO
(grinning)
Touché, brother.

MINARDI
(defensive)

I do read her other stuff, but she likes science, so I try to
keep her updated.

MILO

Sir, she liked discovering science,
not listening to someone else reading
about it.

Niso holds up a data pad.

NISO

We brought alternatives. Poetry.
Music. That terrible action series you
both used to watch.

MILO

"Starfire Squadron." Seventeen seasons
of scientifically questionable space
adventures.

NISO

Commander Belle used to yell at the
screen about their "ridiculous
physics.

(mimics Belle's gestures, pointing
at an imaginary screen)

That's not how hyperspace works! You
can't just reverse the polarity!

MILO

(joining in, imitating Belle's
voice)

"And why are they firing lasers in a
vacuum with sound effects?"

MINARDI

(small smile, remembering)

I think secretly she loved it.

MILO

Maybe she'd prefer being annoyed by
fictional stupidity than educated by
factual boredom.

NISO

Plus, if she can hear you, she's
probably been trying to correct your
pronunciation for months.

MINARDI

(laughing despite himself)

My pronunciation is fine.

MILO
You say "quantum" like "kwon-tum."

MINARDI
(shaking his head, amused)
When did you two become so wise?

MILO
After months of watching you try to
science your way through grief.

NISO
We learned from watching you do
everything wrong.

MINARDI
Alright. What terrible episode should
we start with?

NISO
Season One, Episode One: "The Plasma
Cannon Incident."

MILO
Warning: Commander Belle's going to
hate the orbital mechanics.

MINARDI
(settling back)
Good. Maybe she'll wake up to switch
it off.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL FACILITY CORRIDOR -
EARLY EVENING

MILO and NISO exit Belle's room and nearly collide with
LIEUTENANTS JACE and MARA.

JACE
(mock-friendly)
Hey, look -- it's the Huntsman twins.
What are you doing here? Finally
figured out how to fix your Captain's
broken wife?

MARA

(smirking)

Or maybe you're here to calculate the exact probability of her recovery? Make another one of your little charts?

NISO

(cool contempt)

Actually, we're visiting our Commander. She's been in a coma since our last mission.

(pointed)

But you've probably never been on a real mission.

Mara's expression shifts - for a split second, genuine concern crosses her face at the mention of Belle's condition. Then anger flares and she shoves Niso's shoulder.

MARA

Watch your mouth, kid. We've seen plenty of action.

MILO steps protectively between them, his hand moving toward Mara's wrist as she shoves Niso again. The door slides open quietly.

MINARDI appears in the doorway, takes in the scene with a single glance. His presence alone seems to change the air pressure in the corridor.

MINARDI

(calm, but with steel underneath)

Everything alright here?

His eyes meet Mara's. She steps back from the twins, suddenly aware of their location.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

(still calm)

This is a medical facility. People are trying to heal.

Mara and Jace brush past him. Mara mutters something inaudible.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

(to Milo and Niso)

You two okay?

NISO
(hands trembling slightly)
We're fine, sir.

Minardi glances back at Belle's room, the weight of everything pressing down.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "FIVE MONTHS INTO STASIS"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL RESEARCH LAB - DAY

The sterile lab hums with quiet efficiency. PROFESSOR WEAVER manipulates a holographic brain scan floating before them. The blue crystalline pathways pulse weakly, noticeably dimmer than before.

PROFESSOR WEAVER
(pointing to the fading blue
networks)
Watch this comparison.

The hologram splits, showing Belle's brain from three months ago alongside the current scan. The difference is striking.

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D)
My team is unsure why, but we speculate they may have been communicating with something on the quantum level -- possibly the Wanderer Asteroid itself.

Weaver adjusts the display. The blue pathways pulse in a rhythmic pattern.

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
(tracing the pattern with her
finger)
This isn't random. There's structure here... like they're talking to something.

REDBACK
But it's weakening?

PROFESSOR WEAVER
(thoughtful, studying the data)
Maybe they already said what they
(MORE)

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D)
needed to say.

The hologram shows the signal pattern gradually weakening over time. Redback and Minardi lock eyes - the implications are clear to both military minds.

MINARDI
So this is good news for Belle?

PROFESSOR WEAVER
Very good news. If the activity continues to decrease, it will enable Belle's own consciousness to return much sooner than we anticipated.

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D)
Until that happens we still need to continue our work.

Weaver swipes the display. The brain scan transforms, showing thousands of tiny nanobots moving like microscopic silver fish through Belle's neural pathways.

PROFESSOR WEAVER
So instead of fighting the crystals, we work around them.

The nanobots weave between the blue crystalline structures, forming delicate mesh networks that connect the gaps.

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D)
Think of it as... building bridges. Where the crystals broke connections, the nanobots make new ones.

Minardi watches the silver mesh pulse in harmony with Belle's brainwaves.

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
Essentially, we're building her a hybrid mind.

MINARDI
Would familiar environments help? The work she loved, similar surroundings, and being around the people she cares about.

PROFESSOR WEAVER
Definitely. After five months in
(MORE)

PROFESSOR WEAVER (CONT'D)
stasis, she'll need intensive
rehabilitation and therapy. Initially,
only a few hours of activity daily.

MINARDI
And her mind? When might we see...
Belle?

Weaver hesitates, studying the hologram. The silver nanobots
continue their delicate dance around the blue crystals.

PROFESSOR WEAVER
Unknown. But if the crystals continue
to decrease their influence, it could
be within a month. (pause, meeting his
eyes) Captain, right now, she's not
living. This gives her a chance.

Minardi stares at the hybrid neural network - part human,
part artificial, part alien. A long moment passes. Minardi
watches the hologram fade, leaving only the sterile reality
of the medical lab. Through the observation window, he can
see Belle in her stasis chamber, still and silent.

MINARDI
(to himself)
She always was something more.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
(quiet, determined)
Do it.

The hologram pulses once, as if responding to his decision.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - CORRIDOR - DAY

The industrial corridor echoes with their footsteps as steam
hisses from overhead pipes.

MINARDI
Are you thinking what I'm thinking?

REDBACK
I assume you're talking about the
signal?

MINARDI
Yeah, it doesn't make sense. Why stop?

REDBACK

No idea. But I suspect we may find out. Their footsteps fade as they disappear around a corner, leaving the ominous implication hanging in the air.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT TWO

FADE IN:

ACT THREE

SUPER: "THREE WEEKS LATER - AI BELLE ACTIVATION"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL LAB - DAY

Belle lies in a specialized medical bed, free from stasis for the first time in almost five months. Her body looks healthier, surrounded by monitoring equipment. Minardi stands anxiously beside PROFESSOR WEAVER, his hands gripping the bed rail.

PROFESSOR WEAVER

(adjusting monitoring equipment)

Remember, her exposure was massive and traumatic. But the foundation is there -- she'll find her way back.

Weaver's fingers dance across a holographic interface. Belle's vital signs pulse steadily on the displays -- heartbeat, brain activity, neural pathways flickering with silver nanobots.

MINARDI

(voice trembling, leaning closer)

How will she react?

PROFESSOR WEAVER

(stepping back from the controls)

We're about to find out. Gateway, allow Belle to wake now.

The lab's lighting shifts subtly warmer. Belle's eyelids flutter, then open. Her gaze unfocused at first, pupils struggling to track the ceiling lights.

MINARDI

(reaching toward her, whispered)

Belle?

BELLE

(voice glitching, mechanical)

Where am...?

Her right pupil dilates normally; the left remains fixed like a camera aperture. A tear slips down -- she wipes it away with robotic precision, her fingers moving in perfectly measured increments.

Her posture shifts, becoming unnaturally straight. Her voice becomes Belle's, but hollow.

AI BELLE
 (head tilting at an unnatural
 angle)
 Hello, Professor Weaver, Captain
 Minardi. How wonderful to see you both
 again.

The words hit Minardi like a blow -- Belle's face, Belle's
 voice -- but her eyes scan them like a security camera.

MINARDI
 (stumbling backward, stunned)
 Belle... do you know who I am?

AI BELLE
 (processing, head tilting the
 other way)
 You are Captain Minardi, my commanding
 officer and spouse. We have been
 married for eight years.

Each word technically correct, delivered like computer data.
 Minardi's grip tightens on the bed rail, knuckles white.

MINARDI
 (voice breaking, leaning forward
 desperately)
 Belle, it's me. It's Min.

AI BELLE
 (processing indicator lights
 flickering in her eyes)
 Yes. Min is the informal designation
 you prefer in domestic settings. She
 switches on a perfect, artificial
 smile -- too wide, held too long.

AI BELLE (CONT'D)
 I am pleased to be functional again.
 When may I return to active duty?

Her smile vanishes instantly, like a switched-off light.
 Minardi stares, horrified.

PROFESSOR WEAVER
 (moving closer, voice gentle)
 Commander, how do you feel?

AI BELLE
 examining her own hands with
 scientific interest) I do not
 (MORE)

AI BELLE (CONT'D)
experience feelings. My emotional
responses are simulated through my AI
protocols.

Minardi stumbles backward, hand to his mouth, knocking over a
chair that CLATTERS to the floor.

MINARDI
(barely a whisper)
Oh god... what have we done?

AI BELLE
(turning toward the sound with
mechanical precision)
Captain, your biometric readings
indicate distress. Are you
experiencing a medical emergency?

The lack of concern breaks something inside Minardi. His
breathing becomes ragged.

PROFESSOR WEAVER
(moving between them, supportive)
Captain, this is just the beginning.
Her original personality should still
emerge; we need to give her time.

AI BELLE
(still observing Minardi
clinically)
Is there anything you require,
Captain?

MINARDI
(standing abruptly, backing toward
the door)
I... I need some air.

He rushes toward the door, his footsteps echoing in the
sterile space.

AI BELLE
(calling after him with perfect
diction)
Captain, the medical facility
maintains optimal atmospheric
conditions. Additional air circulation
is unnecessary.

Minardi exits, shoulders shaking. Through the closing door,

we see him lean against the corridor wall, sliding down it slowly.

AI Belle turns back to Professor Weaver, her expression returning to neutral observation mode.

AI BELLE (CONT'D)
(matter-of-factly)
Did I respond incorrectly to Captain
Minardi's distress?

Professor Weaver stares at her, the weight of what they've created settling in.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "ONE WEEK POST-ACTIVATION"

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MEDICAL BAY - NIGHT

AI Belle sits upright in a regular medical bed, her posture mechanically perfect. She holds a data pad with precise finger placement, her eyes tracking the text in measured sweeps. Minardi slouches in a chair beside her, dark circles under his eyes, his gaze never leaving her face, searching for any spark of recognition.

The room's soft lighting casts gentle shadows, but Belle seems unaffected by the intimate atmosphere.

MINARDI
(leaning forward slightly)
Professor Weaver is amazed with your
physical recovery, Belle. Your muscle
tone, coordination -- it's happening
months ahead of schedule.

Belle sets down the data pad with mechanical precision, her hands folding in her lap at perfect right angles.

AI BELLE
(clinical, matter-of-fact)
My body... it's healing faster than it
should. The crystals are... helping
somehow.

MINARDI
(watching her face intently)
He thinks the same crystals that
(MORE)

MINARDI (CONT'D)
damaged your mind might be helping
your body heal faster.

AI BELLE
(head tilting in that unnatural
way)
An interesting paradox. Simultaneous
hindrance and enhancement.

Minardi shifts closer, his voice dropping to something more intimate.

MINARDI
Do you remember our first mission
together?

AI BELLE
(accessing data, eyes flickering)
I have records of our joint service.

MINARDI
(desperate, reaching toward her)
Not records. Memories.

Belle's left hand twitches -- a micro-movement, almost imperceptible. Her mechanical posture wavers slightly. For a fleeting moment, her eyes lose their digital precision and soften, as if a shadow of recognition passes through like sunlight breaking through clouds.

BELLE
(voice changing, becoming warmer)
You... you were nervous. Hid it well,
though.

The change is startling. Minardi freezes, barely breathing, afraid to break the spell.

Belle turns toward the polished metal surface of a nearby medical cart -- her reflection distorted but recognizable. Her hand rises toward her face, trembling as she tries to touch her cheek, but stops inches away. Her fingers hover, shaking with frustration at the disconnect between mind and body.

BELLE (CONT'D)
(confused, almost frightened)
I can see myself, but I can't... I
don't feel...

Minardi, witnessing her struggle, slowly reaches out. His hand gently covers her trembling fingers, guiding them the final distance to her cheek. The contact is electric -- Belle's eyes widen with the first genuine recognition we've seen.

BELLE (CONT'D)
 (touching her skin, wonder in her voice)
 The crystals inside feel... young.
 Like it's just learning what it can become.

Her fingers explore her own face as if discovering it for the first time. Minardi keeps his hand over hers, anchoring her to the moment.

MINARDI
 (voice thick with emotion)
 This is you, Belle, here now, not the AI or the crystals. Hold onto it.

Belle's eyes meet his in the reflection, and for this moment, she's completely present -- vulnerable, confused, but unmistakably herself.

BELLE
 (whispered)
 Min... I'm scared.

MINARDI
 (squeezing her hand gently)
 I know. But you're not alone, and you're getting better.

The moment stretches between them, fragile and precious, before Belle's expression begins to shift back toward the mechanical. But something has changed -- a crack in the AI facade that wasn't there before.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MESS HALL - NIGHT

MARA sits alone at a corner table, methodically field-stripping and cleaning her sidearm. Her movements are precise, almost meditative. A group of OFFICERS at a nearby table laugh loudly. One mimics Captain Minardi's voice, mocking him. Mara's hands pause briefly, her expression

hardening. JACE approaches with a tray, sits uninvited across from her.

JACE
Mind? Everywhere else is full.

Mara shrugs, continues her work. Jace watches her hands.

JACE (CONT'D)
You know, most people use the armory
for that.

MARA
Most people don't do it right.

Jace notices her glancing at the mocking officers.

JACE
Bothers you, huh?

MARA
What?

JACE
Them. Talking about Minardi like that.

Mara reassembles the weapon with quick, efficient movements.

MARA
They don't know what they're talking
about.

JACE
I thought you hated the Huntsman crew.

Mara holsters her weapon, meets his eyes.

MARA
I respect competence. Minardi's a good
Captain. They're just...

JACE
Idiots?

A ghost of a smile crosses Mara's face.

MARA
Something like that.

She stands to leave.

JACE
You're full of surprises, Viper.

MARA
Good. Keep it that way.

She exits, leaving Jace intrigued by this glimpse beneath her armor.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - RESIDENTIAL CORRIDOR - EVENING

Minardi and AI Belle walk through the softly lit residential corridor, their footsteps echoing off polished walls. Belle's gait is mechanically precise, but her eyes dart at the unfamiliar surroundings -- residential quarters, family photos visible through doorways, the distant sound of children playing.

AI BELLE
(stopping abruptly, voice tight)
The facilities in the medical ward
were sufficient. Additional
accommodation is not necessary.

Her hands clench and unclench at her sides.

MINARDI
Dr. Alain thinks being in familiar
surroundings will help your recovery.

AI BELLE
I do not understand the therapeutic
benefit of environmental displacement.

MINARDI
It's not displacement. It's going
home.

Belle looks down the corridor toward their apartment door, visible in the distance.

AI BELLE
(quieter)
I have no stored data about... home.

MINARDI
(offering his arm)
Then let's go see what we can
remember.

After a moment's hesitation, Belle (breaking through) takes

his arm. Her grip is too tight, but she allows him to guide her forward.

As they approach the apartment door, Belle's steps slow. The nameplate reads "MINARDI" in simple letters. She stares at it.

BELLE/AI BELLE
(whispered)
Captain... I am experiencing...
uncertainty.

MINARDI
Uncertainty is a perfectly normal
emotion. It shows that the real you is
breaking through.

He places his palm on the door scanner. The lock disengages with a soft chime.

INT. MINARDI AND BELLE'S APARTMENT - EVENING

Minardi opens the door to their apartment -- a time capsule of their life together. AI Belle follows, scanning the space with clinical detachment, but there's something different now -- a tension in her posture, as if she's bracing for something she can't identify.

MINARDI
It's pretty much the same. We chose
this place for the view of the docking
bays.

Belle moves stiffly into the space, her head turning in sharp, mechanical sweeps as she catalogues everything.

AI BELLE
This environment contains significant
personal artifacts.

But her voice lacks its usual clinical certainty. There's a tremor underneath.

Minardi moves to the kitchen, opens a cabinet, revealing Belle's exotic spice collection. MINARDI These are from worlds we visited together.

AI Belle examines a jar with scientific interest.

AI BELLE (CONT'D)

Molecular composition suggests origin from a high-sulfur atmosphere planet.

MINARDI

(deflated)

Risa Prime. Shore leave after Kepler Station. You bought that for good luck.

In the living area, Minardi activates a holographic display of photos.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

I thought maybe seeing these might help.

Images cycle: Young Minardi and Belle at the Academy, laughing. Their wedding day under starlight. Finally, Belle is pregnant, and Minardi's hands are over hers.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

(voice a whisper)

Our baby. If it were a boy... we were going to name him Cillian, after my father.

Belle's hand moves instinctively to her abdomen. Her expression shifts -- confusion, faint pain.

BELLE

(struggling, breakthrough)

Cillian... we... yellow for the nursery. Wanted it to be a surprise

Minardi, moved, places a hand on Belle's shoulder. She runs her fingers over the hologram.

But the AI personality reasserts control.

AI BELLE

I am... sorry for your loss.

MINARDI

Our loss, Belle. He was our son.

A long, uncomfortable silence.

AI BELLE

Captain... Min. If you require
(MORE)

AI BELLE (CONT'D)
physical intimacy, I am programmed to
provide companionship appropriate to
our marital status.

Minardi stares, horrified and heartbroken.

MINARDI
(standing quickly)
No. I need my wife, not a program
designed to fulfill duties.

AI BELLE
(confused)
I do not understand the distinction.

MINARDI
(sitting back, exhausted)
I know. And that's the problem.

He looks at her, sadness overwhelming.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
I need some air. I'm going for a walk.

AI BELLE
The station maintains constant
atmospheric conditions. A walk will
not improve air quality.

MINARDI
(pausing at the door)
It's just an expression, Belle.

He leaves. AI Belle remains on the couch, staring at the
blank holographic display -- a void where connection once
lived.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - CORRIDORS - NIGHT

Minardi moves through dim corridors lined with exposed
conduits and warning lights. As he enters the docking bay,
sparks shower from an overhead welder working on damaged hull
plating. Heavy AUTOMATONS lumber past cargo containers, their
mechanical steps echoing off steel walls. Steam vents hiss as
he approaches the Huntsman.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - ENGINEERING BAY - NIGHT

The bay glows softly under standby lights. The low reactor
hum is interrupted by intimate laughter. Minardi steps

inside, curious -- then stops, surprised.

CHIEF SULLIVAN and ADMIRAL REDBACK sit close together at a workbench, a bottle of whiskey between them. Redback's hand rests on Sullivan's knee as they share a private moment. Seeing Minardi, she quickly pulls her hand away. They freeze, caught.

MINARDI

(raising an eyebrow, slight smile)
Sorry to intrude. Admiral, I didn't realize you and Sullivan knew each other so... well.

They exchange a look -- part embarrassment, part defiance -- then laugh awkwardly but genuinely.

SULLIVAN

We served together on the Resolute during the Duality Wars. She saved my ass more than once.

REDBACK

(with fond familiarity)
And Sully taught me how to cheat at cards.
(grins)
Come on, Captain, join us. There's enough trouble without old friends pretending they're strangers.

Minardi sits, noting the easy intimacy between them. Sullivan pours him a glass with slightly unsteady hands.

MINARDI

I guess that was before my time.

REDBACK

What brings you here, Min? Can't sleep?

MINARDI

I needed to see the old girl. And... I've been thinking about Belle. She's not getting better in that apartment. The ship was her real home.

SULLIVAN

That's what I keep telling him, Admiral. The Huntsman's not just a ship -- it's family.

MINARDI

With respect, Ma'am, I've been watching the Pardosa trainers. They don't look like the trainer type -- they look bored and take it out on the cadets.

REDBACK

(sighs, swirling her whiskey)
Bar fight that got out of hand.
They're here as a final warning.

SULLIVAN

(leaning back)
Troublemakers, huh?

REDBACK

They were good soldiers when it mattered. Young, but they proved themselves.

(sighs)
Now they're just... bored and looking for some action.

MINARDI

They're sharp but lack discipline. They need real experience -- the kind you only get on a real ship.

REDBACK

(intrigued)
You're suggesting we recommission the Huntsman as a training vessel?

MINARDI

Yes, let Belle serve as Science Officer again. Let recruits learn from the best. And let the Pardosa trio and the cadets get tested for real.

Sullivan jumps in.

SULLIVAN

The ship's in top shape, Admiral. All she needs is a crew and nav updates.

REDBACK

(warming)
It's ambitious. And not cheap.

MINARDI

But necessary. The next crisis won't wait. We need officers who can handle the real thing.

A long pause. Redback weighs the idea.

REDBACK

Six months. Trial period. If it works, I'll push for a full program.

Minardi extends his hand.

MINARDI

Thank you, Admiral.

Redback shakes it, then claps Sullivan's shoulder.

REDBACK

Don't thank me yet -- you're on the hook for this.

(pauses)

And Minardi... I hope this helps Belle find her way back.

MINARDI

So do I, Admiral. So do I.

The three share a quiet moment, the Huntsman's hum a steady comfort.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT THREE

FADE IN:

ACT FOUR

HUNTSMAN RECOMMISSIONING

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MAIN CORRIDOR - DAY

The ship awakens around them. Lights flicker on in sequence as ENGINEERS work their way down the corridor, calling out system checks. RECRUITS carry duffel bags and personal items, their voices echoing off metal walls as they claim bunks. Minardi walks with Sullivan, observing the controlled chaos.

SULLIVAN

She's coming back to life, Captain.

In the distance, BELLE appears at her quarters' threshold, box in hand. She hesitates, then steps inside. Minardi notices, his expression softening.

MINARDI

Let's hope we all do.

The corridor bustles with renewed purpose as the Huntsman transforms from monument to living ship once again.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

SUPER: "ONE MONTH LATER"

INT. THE PARDOSA - TACTICAL TRAINING ROOM - DAY

JACE oversees a simulation of ship-to-ship combat. CADETS operate weapon system interfaces as holographic targets appear around them.

One CADET hesitates on a difficult intercept, missing the target.

JACE

That's a dead ship. Reset.

The simulation resets. Jace steps closer to the struggling Cadet.

JACE (CONT'D)

You're overthinking it. The targeting computer gives you the solution, but you need to anticipate movement.

He demonstrates on the console, his fingers dancing across controls with practiced efficiency.

JACE (CONT'D)
See? Lead the target. The Huntsman's
gunners won't give you a second
chance.

The Cadet tries again, successfully hits the target.

JACE (CONT'D)
Better. Now keep that up for another
hour.

TANNER enters. Jace straightens.

TANNER
Lieutenant. A word.

As Jace steps away:

JACE
(to Cadet, quietly)
My first combat, I missed three times
before landing a hit. Just don't tell
anyone I said that.

A rare moment of vulnerability before his cocky demeanor
returns.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - DAY (TRAINING)

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE

The Huntsman and Pardosa face off a dense, glittering
asteroid field ahead of them. The Pardosa's Mark VIII shuttle
detaches, engines flaring.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE

Minardi stands behind Niso and Milo at the helm, eyes
narrowed at the tactical display.

MINARDI
All right, team. Our objective is
simple -- make it through to the far
side. The Pardosa will do everything
it can to stop us. Stay sharp.

Milo's console pings.

MILO

Uh, Captain... the Pardosa's launching
its shuttle.

On the main screen, the sleek Mark VIII shuttle detaches,
engines flaring.

MINARDI

(surprised, then annoyed)
Is that a Mark Eight? Since when did
the Pardosa have a prototype shuttle?

NISO

It arrived two weeks ago, sir. For
trials.

MINARDI

(irritated)
And nobody thought to tell me?

MILO

(awkward)
We did, sir. The day it arrived.

AI BELLE

(voice, precise)
Confirmed. Notification was logged at
0900 hours, two weeks ago.

Minardi shoots a look at the ceiling, exasperated.

MINARDI

(to himself)
Maybe if I wasn't so busy with AI
Belle's diagnostics...

The crew exchanges glances, trying not to smile.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

All right, let's focus. Niso, Milo --
take us in. Eyes on the shuttle.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE

The Huntsman glides into the swirling rocks, the Mark VIII
shuttle darting after it like a predator. The Pardosa
maintains a high vantage point, looming above the field.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE

Mara, at the weapons console, is laser-focused, jaw tight.

Tanner stands behind her, arms crossed, overseeing the bridge. The younger cadets at navigation and sensors are tense, hands flying over controls as the ship weaves through the asteroids.

MARA

(frustrated, snapping)

Hold her steady! I can't get a lock if you're zig-zagging like a drunk on shore leave!

A nervous cadet glances back, swallowing hard.

CADET

Sorry, Lieutenant! The debris field's denser than the sim --

MARA

(interrupting)

Excuses don't win battles. Just keep her steady!

Tanner steps forward, voice calm but firm.

TANNER

Easy, Mara. They're doing fine.

(beat, to the cadets, with a wry smile)

Maybe if the lieutenant wasn't firing her mouth off so much, she'd actually hit something. The bridge erupts in nervous laughter. Even Mara cracks a reluctant grin, rolling her eyes. MARA Yeah, yeah. Just keep us in one piece, rookies.

Tanner leans in, lowering his voice for Mara.

TANNER (CONT'D)

(quiet, approving)

You're good, but you're not alone. Let them breathe.

Mara nods, tension easing. All feel Tanner's steady presence.

INT. MARK VIII SHUTTLE - COCKPIT

Jace, piloting with cocky precision, weaves through the asteroids, eyes locked on the Huntsman ahead. He opens a channel.

JACE (V.O.)

Huntsman, you're not shaking me that easy. Try not to scratch the paint -- I'd hate to have to rescue you.

Milo rolls her eyes on the Huntsman bridge; Niso grins.

The twins work in perfect sync, weaving through asteroids. The hull GROANS under stress as they bank hard around a spinning rock face.

NISO

Let's show him what we can do.

The Mark VIII shuttle mirrors every move, vanishing behind debris only to reappear in their blind spot. MICRO-METEORS pepper the shields, creating brief flashes of light.

MINARDI

He's good. Target the largest asteroids -- kick up some dust.

MILO

On it.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE

The Huntsman's weapons fire, shattering asteroids. Debris clouds the field.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE

The ship's frame CREAKS as they maneuver through the expanding debris cloud. Static crackles across their displays.

MARA

(frustrated)

I can't get a lock through this mess!

TANNER

Easy. They're blinding themselves too.

A micro-meteor shower PINGS against their shields like metallic rain.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE

The Huntsman bursts from the dust cloud, scoring a hit on the Pardosa. But the Mark VIII shuttle swoops up from below, catching them off-guard.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE

The hull SHUDDERS from the simulated impact. Warning lights flash.

JACE (V.O.)
Nice flying, but you left your back
door open.

MINARDI
(grudging respect)
That's how you keep each other honest.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE

Mara slams her fist on the console, but Tanner just grins.

TANNER
Not bad, Huntsman. Not bad at all.

He glances at the cadets.

TANNER (CONT'D)
You kept your heads. That's what
matters.

The cadets look relieved, pride flickering in their eyes.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE

Both ships drift, simulated damage flickering on their hulls.
The exercise is declared a draw.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE

The crew exhales, adrenaline high. Minardi glances at the tactical display, then at his team.

MINARDI
Good effort everyone. But next time,
we don't let them get the last word.

The crew grins, united by the challenge.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE - DAY

SUPER: "TWO WEEKS LATER - FINAL BATTLE SIMULATION"

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE - DAY

On the Pardosa, Tanner stands at tactical, reviewing simulation parameters. The bridge

The COMMUNICATIONS OFFICER looks up from her console.

COMM OFFICER

Sir, Captain Minardi is requesting a secure channel.

TANNER

In my ready room.

INT. THE PARDOSA - READY ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Tanner activates the viewscreen. MINARDI appears, expression grave.

MINARDI

Lieutenant Commander. I've received orders from Admiral Redback. A mining station in sector four is under attack by raiders.

TANNER

We'll prepare to assist immediately.

MINARDI

Negative. The Huntsman will respond alone.

Tanner's expression shifts subtly - confusion, then concern.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

The raid is being led by former Captain Voss.

This lands heavily. Tanner straightens.

TANNER

Voss? He served with half my crew during the Duality Wars.

MINARDI

Exactly. Redback thinks your crew might hesitate. Against Voss.

TANNER

(controlled anger)
My crew has no loyalty to traitors,
(MORE)

TANNER (CONT'D)

Captain.

MINARDI

Raiders have already boarded the station. They're trying to breach the command center where the miners are barricaded. There's a vault in there containing significant precious metals.

TANNER

All the more reason to bring both ships.

MINARDI

Marines are en route, ETA thirty minutes. Our orders are to engage the raider vessels and prevent their escape until reinforcements arrive.

TANNER

Captain, with respect--

MINARDI

These are direct orders, Lieutenant Commander. The Pardosa is to stand down.

The connection terminates. Tanner remains still for a moment, decision forming.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER

Tanner strides onto the bridge, purpose in every step.

TANNER

All hands, battle stations.

The crew looks up, surprised.

HELM OFFICER

Sir? I thought the exercises were cancelled?

TANNER

Mining Station Helios is under attack by raiders led by former Captain Voss.

Murmurs ripple through the bridge. Mara and Jace exchange looks.

TANNER (CONT'D)

The Huntsman has been ordered to respond. We have been ordered to stand down.

He pauses, meeting each officer's eyes.

TANNER (CONT'D)

I am choosing to disregard that order.

Silence falls across the bridge.

TANNER (CONT'D)

Anyone who objects will have their dissent noted in the ship's log, without prejudice. This is my decision alone.

No one speaks. Jace steps forward.

JACE

Voss was my commanding officer for three years. He's also a traitor who deserves whatever's coming to him.

MARA

He's good in a fight. Too good. They'll need our help.

Tanner nods, grateful.

TANNER

Helm, set course for Helios Station. Tactical, recalibrate weapons systems. And engage cloaking systems - let's give the raiders a surprise.

TANNER (CONT'D)

(to Jace)

Lieutenant Kellen, prepare the Mark VIII shuttle. I want you to provide close tactical support when we engage.

JACE

(grinning)

With pleasure, sir.

EXT. SPACE - MINING STATION HELIOS - LATER

The Huntsman drops out of full impulse, weapons hot. Three small raider fighters and two Pardosa-class vessels surround

the Mining station, which is attached to a huge meteorite.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE

MINARDI

Target the fighters first. Open fire.

The Huntsman engages, immediately destroying one fighter. The other vessels turn their attention to this new threat.

EXT. SPACE - CONTINUOUS

The Huntsman weaves through enemy fire, taking down a second fighter. Suddenly, both Pardosa-class raider vessels focus their fire on the Huntsman. Its shields flicker dangerously.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE

The ship rocks with impacts. Consoles spark.

TACTICAL OFFICER

Shields at 62%, Captain!

MINARDI

Evasive pattern delta! Concentrate
fire on the lead vessel!

The ship SHUDDERS under enemy fire. Metal GROANS as the hull flexes. Sparks shower from overloaded circuits.

TACTICAL OFFICER

Shields at thirty percent!

Micro-debris PATTERS against the viewports like deadly hail.

MINARDI

(grimly)

Evasive maneuvers. We're not letting
them escape with those miners' haul.

Suddenly, a new contact appears on sensors.

COMMANDER BELLE

Captain! Another ship decloaking off
our starboard bow!

Minardi's expression shifts from concern to surprise as the Pardosa appears on the viewscreen.

EXT. SPACE - CONTINUOUS

The Pardosa decloaks, immediately firing on the raider vessels. From its launch bay, the Mark VIII shuttle piloted by JACE streaks into the battle, targeting the remaining fighter with precision.

INT. MARK VIII SHUTTLE - COCKPIT

Jace maneuvers with exceptional skill, evading enemy fire while targeting the raider fighter.

JACE

Just like target practice. Except the targets shoot back.

He fires, disabling the fighter's engines.

JACE (CONT'D)

Scratch one raider. Moving to support position.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Tanner stands calm amid the chaos of battle.

TANNER

Target the lead vessel's weapons systems. Lieutenant Kellen, harass their flanks. Keep them off balance.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE

Minardi watches the Pardosa join the fight, a complex mix of emotions crossing his face.

MINARDI

Tactical, coordinate fire with the Pardosa. Let's make this count.

EXT. SPACE - CONTINUOUS

The battle intensifies. With the Huntsman and Pardosa working in tandem, and Jace's shuttle darting between larger vessels to deliver precision strikes, forcing the raiders to divide their fire.

INT. MARK VIII SHUTTLE - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Jace targets the weapons array on one of the Pardosa-class raider vessels.

JACE
Taking out their port weapons array...
now.

His shots connect, disabling a section of the raider's weapons.

JACE (CONT'D)
That's for betraying the uniform,
Voss.

EXT. SPACE - CONTINUOUS

A new ship drops out of Full impulse - the Marine vessel. The raider ships, seeing the odds turn decisively against them, break off and retreat.

INT. MINING STATION HELIOS - COMMAND CENTER - LATER

MARINE COMMANDER leads his team through the station, engaging and subduing the raiders who were left behind when their ships fled.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - READY ROOM - LATER

Minardi faces Tanner across his desk, expression stern.

MINARDI
You disobeyed a direct order,
Lieutenant Commander.

TANNER
Yes, sir.

MINARDI
That's grounds for court martial.

TANNER
I know, sir.

A long pause. Minardi's stern expression softens slightly.

MINARDI
Your actions also saved this ship and
everyone aboard that station.

He stands, approaches Tanner.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
I've spoken with Admiral Redback. I
informed him that the Pardosa and her
(MORE)

MINARDI (CONT'D)
crew demonstrated their loyalty beyond
question today.

Tanner remains at attention, but surprise shows in his eyes.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
The official record will show that the
Pardosa received conflicting orders
due to communications interference.
Understood?

TANNER
Understood, sir. Thank you.

MINARDI

DON'T THANK ME YET. YOU'LL BE RUNNING
DOUBLE SIMULATION DRILLS FOR THE NEXT
MONTH AS... PENANCE.

A hint of a smile crosses Tanner's face.

TANNER
Worth it, sir.

Minardi extends his hand. Tanner takes it - a new respect
formed between them.

MINARDI
Next time you plan to save my ship,
Lieutenant... give me a heads up
first.

TANNER
No promises, Captain.

They share a moment of understanding - rivals becoming
allies.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. ADMIRAL REDBACK'S OFFICE - DAY (THREE DAYS LATER)

Admiral Redback stands at his window, the vastness of space
beyond. Minardi sits across from him, posture relaxed but
eyes alert.

ADMIRAL REDBACK
Command loved what you did here.
They're making it permanent, Min. Two
years, full program..

MINARDI
Thank you, Admiral. The crew's
dedication made it possible.

ADMIRAL REDBACK
And Belle? I've heard that her
breakthroughs are becoming more
frequent -- longer stretches of
conscious awareness and sharper
decision-making.

MINARDI
She's definitely improving. Sometimes
she's completely herself for up to
fifteen minutes. It's not consistent,
but... It's hope

ADMIRAL REDBACK
Sometimes hope is all we need to keep
moving forward, Captain.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. MINARDI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

Minardi lies in bed, exhausted from the day's events. His
eyes close --

FADE TO:

MINARDI'S VISION - BEGINS

EXT. TEMPLE OF THE KEEPERS - NIGHT

Minardi finds himself standing outside an ancient temple
under alien stars. The architecture is both magnificent and
otherworldly -- carved from stone that seems to breathe with
age.

He approaches the entrance cautiously. Through the massive
doorway, he can see BLUE LIGHT shimmering and dancing off the
internal walls like liquid starlight.

He steps closer, trying to peer inside. The light pulses

rhythmically, almost like a heartbeat.

Then -- movement within.

BELLE emerges from the temple's depths, walking toward him through the blue radiance. She's fully herself -- her form catching and refracting the light into prismatic patterns.

She steps through. They EMBRACE, and Minardi pulls her close, feeling the warmth of her skin.

MINARDI

(whispered)

Am I having a lucid dream, or are you really here?

BELLE

(smiling)

Actually, you're in my vision, I brought you here. I'm learning, Min. Learning to bridge both worlds. The Crystal... It's not what I thought. It's been waiting so long. Behind Belle, deeper in the temple, Minardi glimpses the source of the light -- a MASSIVE CRYSTALLINE STRUCTURE pulsing with that same neon blue energy. HOODED FIGURES stand in silent vigil around it.

BELLE (CONT'D)

They're trying to help me understand. The Keepers... they've dedicated their lives to learning from the crystal ever since it crash landed on their planet a long time ago.

(touching his face)

Just like the Keepers, we were chosen. The blue light begins to intensify, washing over them both --

BELLE (CONT'D) (CONT'D)

The Crystal has been broadcasting for billions of years. The Keepers hear only fragments - like trying to understand a symphony by catching single notes. But I'm learning to hear the whole song.

MINARDI'S VISION - ENDS

INT. MINARDI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

Minardi wakes gently from the vision, eyes adjusting to the darkness. A presence above him --

He STARTS as he realizes BELLE is straddling him, her naked form faintly luminescent in the dark, her arms planted on either side of him, her face inches from his.

MINARDI

(fumbling, shocked)

Belle! What are you -- how did you --
why are you in my bedroom?

Belle's lips curve into that familiar mischievous smile he fell in love with.

BELLE

(fully lucid, playful)

I wanted to be close to you. After
holding you in the vision...

(beat, eyes sparkling)

By the way, Captain, this happens to
be our bedroom. The tension breaks.

They both LAUGH -- a real laugh, the kind they haven't shared since before her transformation. For a moment, she's just Belle again, teasing her husband about his formality.

MINARDI

(grinning)

Force of habit. I've been sleeping
alone so long I --

BELLE

(interrupting, tender now)

Not anymore, quiet now. She leans down
and they kiss -- tentatively at first,
then with growing passion. Her skin
glows softly with warmth, not alien
but intimate.

As they embrace, the camera slowly pulls back, giving them privacy as the room's luminescence gently fades to black.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - CORRIDOR - DAY

Minardi walks the corridor, passing officers and crew he's trained. They nod respectfully, acknowledging his leadership

and the program's success.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - ELEVATOR - DAY

Minardi steps into the elevator. As the doors begin to close, a hand stops them -- Belle enters. Her movements are subtly different: less mechanical, more human. BELLE (serious) Min, the crystals, I think they're trying to tell me that something is coming.

MINARDI

(surprised)

Who's coming? BELLE I'm not sure, but I'm sensing the keepers of the Crystals from my visions may be with them.

The elevator lights flicker, then go out. Emergency red lighting snaps on. The station's power grid surges and stabilizes.

COMPUTER VOICE

(distorted)

Power fluctuation detected. Emergency protocols initiated.

The lights stabilize. Minardi's comm chirps.

ADMIRAL REDBACK (V.O.)

(into comm, urgent)

All senior staff to The Command Centre, immediately.

MINARDI

(into comm)

On my way with Commander Belle.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - COMMAND CENTER - DAY

The Command Center hums with tension, illuminated by flickering blue emergency lights. On the main viewscreen, an alien vessel -- The Celestial -- pulses with ancient energy, its fluid hull shifting in mesmerizing patterns. ADMIRAL REDBACK stands at center as MINARDI enters, still shaken from Belle's collapse.

ADMIRAL REDBACK

Min, they were inside our systems before we even saw them. Everything --
(MORE)

ADMIRAL REDBACK (CONT'D)
files, databases, the whole network.

STATION OFFICER
Ma'am, we're receiving a transmission.

ADMIRAL REDBACK
On screen.

A shimmering holographic figure materializes: a luminous humanoid form of pure light -- the CELESTIAL AI. Its voice resonates with ancient calm.

CELESTIAL AI
Greetings. I am the Quantum
consciousness of The Celestial. I
apologize for our intrusion -- it was
necessary to establish communication.
We mean no harm. We do not ordinarily
initiate first contact with
civilizations until they are ready;
however, our circumstances necessitate
an exception on this occasion.

The Celestial AI turns to Belle, its form almost reverent.

CELESTIAL AI (CONT'D)
Commander Belle. We are very limited
in what we can reveal, as we cannot
risk altering events in your timeline.

The AI pauses, choosing its words carefully.

CELESTIAL AI (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
We come from your future. Something
threatens us there; only you can help.

Belle's breath catches, trembling as understanding dawns.

BELLE
(voice breaking)
The dreams, the visions... they've
been preparing me for something,
haven't they?

CELESTIAL AI
We cannot say more. Will you help us?

MINARDI
(gripping Belle's hand)
How do we prepare?

CELESTIAL AI
Our mission is to collect Commander Belle.

MINARDI
(decisive)
Commander Belle is my wife. Where she goes, I go.

CELESTIAL AI
(nodding)
I apologise, we are not familiar with your bonding customs. You may also attend. Do you have any other family?

BELLE
We have a small ship and crew. That is our family.

CELESTIAL AI
Our docking bay is equipped to carry your ship and crew.

MINARDI
(decisive)
We need time to prepare. Ten days. Give us ten days to prepare.

CELESTIAL AI
(nodding)
Ten days is agreed.

MINARDI
I appreciate that you cannot reveal too much because of the impact on timelines, but am I correct in saying that if we are going to some time in the future and Commander Belle is successful in her mission, then we will not be able to return, as the threat you face will happen again?

CELESTIAL AI
You are correct in your assumption.

The Celestial AI vanishes.

The Command Center buzzes with controlled chaos. Officers whisper urgently as holographic displays flicker with data about the massive alien vessel orbiting beyond the Star Portal. Whispers of "invasion" and "end of the world" echo

through corridors.

CAPTAIN NICO MINARDI stands with COMMANDER BELLE, her eyes still faintly glowing from her crystalline connection. ADMIRAL REDBACK addresses the assembled officers, his voice cutting through the din.

ADMIRAL REDBACK

(grave)

The Celestial's transmission is clear -- they're here for a purpose, not conquest. But we're not taking chances. High Command is mobilizing. Senior politicians and military brass arrive within 48 hours. We verify every claim and prepare for the worst.

A SENIOR OFFICER steps forward, voice laced with skepticism.

SENIOR OFFICER

Admiral, how do we know this isn't a setup? They hacked our systems in seconds -- could be probing for weaknesses. Where's proof they're in peril? Why agree to this mission so quickly? We're handing them the keys to our timeline.

Murmurs of agreement ripple through the room. Redback's jaw tightens.

ADMIRAL REDBACK

I share those doubts. But Commander Belle's visions align with their story, and we can't ignore a potential galaxy-wide threat. We'll get answers. For now, we prepare.

Through the viewports, more ships dock -- sleek military vessels and diplomatic shuttles, their arrivals escalating the station's unease.

Belle stands beside Minardi, her expression a mix of determination and vulnerability, the weight of their cosmic mission settling over them both.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT FOUR

FADE IN:

ACT FIVE

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIEFING ROOM - DAY

Minardi stands before a half-empty briefing room. Only Niso, Milo, Sullivan, and Belle are present. The room's dim lights and familiar hum provide sanctuary from the station's chaos.

MINARDI

(voice steady and grave)
I've spoken with Reeves, Webb, and Dr. Oduya. They've chosen to stay behind -- family comes first. Can't blame them.

MINARDI (CONT)

The Celestial departs in ten days. This is a one-way trip into the future. No coming back, no second chances.

He studies the faces of those who remain.

MINARDI

I won't pretend this isn't asking everything of you.
(beat)
But I need to know -- are you in?

The remaining crew -- Niso, Milo, and Sullivan -- exchange glances, then nod with quiet resolve.

NISO

(breaking silence, determined)
We're with you, Captain. All the way.

MILO

No question. But we're three short. How do we fill those gaps?

SULLIVAN

(gruff)
The station's got talent. Need the right people to step up.

Minardi pauses, knowing this won't be easy.

MINARDI

Tanner, Jace, and Mara from the Pardosa. They've got the skills. Six months of simulations and ignoring
(MORE)

MINARDI (CONT'D)
orders to save our asses proved it.
They started rough, but they're
adaptable, tough, and damn good under
pressure.

Niso and Milo exchange skeptical glances.

NISO
(voice rising)
Them? After all the crap they've
pulled? Jace is a hothead, Mara's got
a grudge a light-year wide.

MILO
We can't trust them, Captain. Not with
something this big.

MINARDI
(calm but insistent)
You're not wrong about their flaws.
But that's precisely why they fit.
They've shown growth and good combat
experience. We need that fire. If we
approach them correctly, they'll rise
to the challenge.

The twins relent reluctantly. Sullivan nods approvingly.

SULLIVAN
If you say so, Captain. Let's see if
they surprise us.

FADE OUT.

CUT TO:

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - CORRIDORS - LATER THAT DAY

Minardi and Belle move through crowded corridors. The station
is chaotic -- senior politicians and military ships docking,
heightening unease.

They spot the Pardosa trio near a viewport. Minardi
approaches directly.

MINARDI
Jace, Mara, Tanner. You've all heard
the news by now. The Huntsman is
jumping into the future to fight a
threat that even they can't defeat but
(MORE)

MINARDI (CONT'D)
maybe The Commander can, that's why
we're here. We're short on crew, and
you three have the skills we need --
one-way trip, dangerous, no
obligation. But I've seen you in
action. You adapt; you fight. Are you
in?

The trio processes this. Jace grins, Mara considers, Tanner
remains steady.

JACE
A one-way trip to save the Galaxy?
Sign me up.

MARA
If it's as critical as it sounds...
count me in.

TANNER
We're ready, Captain.

As the group stands, Minardi pulls Tanner aside.

MINARDI
(low, serious)
I need your word -- you keep Jace and
Mara in line -- no repeats of the
past. I'm making you Chief Security
Officer and third in Command. Can I
count on you?

TANNE
(without hesitation)
You have my word, Captain. We'll get
the job done.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - THE FOLLOWING DAY

The bridge hums with quiet efficiency. Minardi stands before
the expanded crew: Belle beside him, with Niso, Milo,
Sullivan, and the three Pardosa transfers - Tanner, Jace, and
Mara. The atmosphere is charged with anticipation.

MINARDI

(standing, authoritative)

We have a critical problem. The Pardosa's Mark VIII shuttle has proven it can give us a significant edge in battle. The prototype is scheduled to return to its home station two days after our departure.

He activates the main tactical display, showing the Pardosa shuttle.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

Command won't let us take the Mark VIII. But we've seen what it can do. We're not leaving without it.

Minardi turns to address Tanner directly.

MINARDI (CONT'D) (CONT'D)

Tanner, I've reviewed your service record. You're a natural leader - steady under pressure, respected by your crew. I'm appointing you Chief Security Officer and Acting Commander whenever Belle is absent.

He gestures to the command station.

MINARDI (CONT'D) (CONT'D)

This is your station during combat operations. You'll coordinate all security protocols and crew safety measures.

TANNER

(straightening with pride)

Understood, Captain. I won't let you down.

MINARDI

I approached Admiral Redback about a final battle simulation in the asteroid belt where we trained before. I told him I'm uncertain about integrating new crew members and want to mix teams to see how they work under different command structures.

SULLIVAN
(gruff approval)
Smart cover story, Captain.

MINARDI
During the operation, we'll execute a covert shuttle swap in the asteroid field. But first, we need to get our people in position without security noticing they're on the wrong ships at the mission's end.

He moves toward the Bridge exit.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
Let me show you how this ship really works.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MAIN CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

The group moves through the ship's main artery, passing crew quarters and service areas. Minardi walks with purpose, the others following.

MINARDI
The simulation is set for two days before departure. Here's how it works: Belle, Milo, and Niso transfer to the Pardosa. Tanner, Jace, and Mara come to the Huntsman. He points to the tactical display in the corridor, showing crew movements.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
Belle, Milo, Niso -- your job is crucial. Keep the Pardosa's cadet crew focused on the simulation. They cannot notice that the wrong shuttle is returning to the docking bay at mission's end.

MINARDI (CONT)
Jace, the night before the heist, I'll escort you to The Huntsman's security. Sullivan will emerge, saying he needs your help fitting a conductor in the engineering department. You stay on the ship overnight and get to our shuttle before the crew arrives.

JACE
(grinning)
Sneaking aboard my own ship. I like
it.

MINARDI
Belle, Niso, get to the Pardosa early.
Baseball cap, Jace's ID. Just in case.
Get to their shuttle before the rest
of the crew arrives. Niso as you
haven't piloted a Mark VIII before,
you'll need to link in with Jace.

NISO
(eyes rolling)
Understood, Captain.

NISO glances to a grinning Jace, who winks at her.
They pass the medical bay entrance. Minardi pauses.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
Mara, this is your secondary station.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MEDICAL BAY - CONTINUOUS

The medical bay is compact but sophisticated. Advanced
diagnostic equipment lines the walls, with a central
treatment bed and surgical suite visible through transparent
barriers.

MINARDI
I've reviewed your medical training.
First-class field medic certification.
You'll be handling dual roles -
Weapons Officer and Emergency Medical
Response.

MARA
(examining the equipment)
Dual roles? That's... ambitious.

MINARDI
The ship has the latest medical
automatons for complex procedures like
surgery. But for trauma, field
medicine, emergency response - that's
you.

He activates a console, showing the medical automaton bay.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

These handle what you can't. You
handle what they can't - the human
element.

MARA

(nodding with growing confidence)
I can work with this.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MAIN CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

They continue walking, passing through different sections of
the ship.

MINARDI

During the mission, when I message you
Protocol 717, that's our cue. Shuttles
launch, we make the swap. Horus will
create a simulated malfunction on our
cadets' monitors. Belle, you'll be
commanding the Pardosa. When you get
the Protocol 717 message, create a
similar malfunction on the Pardosa
Cadets' monitors while the heist
happens.

BELLE

(eyes flickering blue)
I can generate false readings to mask
the shuttle movements on their end.

MINARDI

With both crews experiencing monitor
malfunctions, neither will see what's
happening in the shuttle bays during
the swap.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

The swap happens away from both ships'
sensor range, hidden in the asteroid
shadows.

They approach the engineering section.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - ENGINEERING BAY - CONTINUOUS

The engineering bay thrums with power. The fusion reactor's
glow creates an almost cathedral-like atmosphere. Sullivan
steps forward, in his element.

SULLIVAN

Welcome to the heart of the ship.
She's been upgraded since the war -
newer fusion core, enhanced shielding
systems.

He moves to a control panel, his hands dancing over the
interface.

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)

During the swap, I'll create a
controlled electromagnetic pulse -
looks like system malfunction on their
sensors. Meanwhile, our sensors will
be "recalibrating."

MILO

What about the monitoring ships?

SULLIVAN

Asteroid field's dense enough to
scatter their sensor readings. We'll
be ghosts in the static.

Sullivan looks directly at the three new crew members.

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)

One thing about the Huntsman - she's
not just a ship, she's family. You
take care of her, she takes care of
you.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - MAIN CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

They continue toward the shuttle bay, passing through the
ship's lower sections.

MINARDI

Remember - absolutely no comms during
the actual swap. We rely on timing and
trust.

TANNER

What if something goes wrong during
the swap?

MINARDI

Then we improvise. But this is our
only shot at the Mark VIII.

He looks around the group seriously

MINARDI (CONT'D)

This is a small ship with a small crew. Everyone needs to know each other's role. In an emergency, it can make the difference between life and death.

They reach the shuttle bay entrance.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - SHUTTLE BAY - CONTINUOUS

The shuttle bay doors open to reveal the Huntsman's current shuttle - a battered Mark II, clearly showing its age. Scorch marks, patched hull plating, and jury-rigged systems are visible. It sits in stark contrast to the sleek, modern bay around it.

MINARDI

Jace, you're taking over Operations from Reeves. I know you're trained as a pilot-

JACE

(interrupting, defensive)
I am a pilot. I don't know anything about Operations.

MINARDI

(patient but firm)
Niso's our navigator and pilot, so you'll cover each other. She picked up Operations duties quickly. You'll adapt.

Jace looks at the old shuttle, then back at Minardi.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

Everyone's expected to cover any role in an emergency. That's how small crews survive.

JACE

(staring at the Mark II, then
bursting into laughter)
Now I know why you want our shuttle so badly. That thing looks like my old school bus!

The tension breaks. Even Mara cracks a smile, while Sullivan chuckles.

SULLIVAN
(defensive but amused)
Hey, that "school bus" has never let
us down.

JACE
(still grinning)
And I'm sure it's very... reliable.

MINARDI
(looking around the group)
Questions? Concerns? Once we commit to
this, there's no turning back. We're
not just stealing equipment - we're
crossing a line that changes
everything.

The crew exchanges glances, the weight of the decision
settling over them.

NISO
(determined)
We've come this far. I'm in.

MILO
(nodding)
The mission requires it. Count me in.

One by one, the crew voices their commitment. Minardi nods,
satisfied.

MINARDI
Two days, people. Let's make it count.

FADE TO BLACK

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE - DAY

The asteroid field glitters with danger and opportunity.
Multiple monitoring ships position themselves at safe
distances -- sleek military and media vessels creating a
perimeter around the training zone.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - DAY

The bridge hums with tension. MINARDI stands at the command
station, his jaw tight as he reviews incoming communications.
TANNER, JACE, and MARA have integrated seamlessly with the
crew, while SULLIVAN monitors from Engineering.

MINARDI

(into comm, frustrated)

Admiral, you didn't mention the operation would be televised.

REDBACK (V.O.)

(over comm)

Political decision came down this morning, Captain. High Command wants to showcase the Huntsman's sacrifice and celebrate the first contact with our future allies. The publicity is... considerable. Just make sure you win.

Through the viewscreen, monitoring ships are visible, maintaining formation.

MINARDI

(Text to monitors of Jace, Tanner, Mara, Sullivan, Belle, Niso and Milo)

Change of plans. We go deep into the asteroid field -- as deep as we can. The monitoring ships won't be able to track us through the dense debris.

TANNER

(leans to Minardi, ensuring no cadets can hear)

Captain, that significantly increases collision risk.

MINARDI

(Whispers back)

It's the only way to avoid surveillance during the swap. We'll create a blizzard of asteroid dust and flak to confuse their sensors.

He activates the tactical display.

MINARDI (CONT'D)

Mission parameters have changed. The Pardosa's objective is to traverse the asteroid field before we stop them. Both crews have orders -- the Huntsman must be the victor. Politicians want a show of strength before our departure.

JACE

(message to Minardi from shuttle)
A rigged fight? I can work with that.

MINARDI

(return message)
No time for jokes. The fight may be
rigged, but the danger is real. Those
asteroids don't care about politics.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

BELLE stands at the command position, her eyes flickering
with crystalline light. MILO and NISO work at their stations,
seamlessly integrated with the Pardosa crew. The young cadets
around them buzz with nervous energy.

BELLE

(calm, authoritative)
Helm, take us into the asteroid field.
Deep penetration.

MILO

Acknowledged Commander, navigation
shows high collision probability at
those depths.

BELLE

(eyes glowing faintly)
Trust your instruments and NISO's
guidance. We'll find a path through.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE - CONTINUOUS

Both ships plunge into the asteroid field, disappearing into
the maze of spinning rock and debris. The monitoring ships
hover at the perimeter, their sensors straining to penetrate
the chaos.

The ships weave through massive asteroids, their hulls barely
clearing the spinning debris. The Huntsman fires flack
missiles, creating brilliant explosions that shower the area
with metallic chaff and blinding light.

INT. THE PARDOSA - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

Alarms blare as the ship shudders from a glancing blow with
an asteroid.

CADET OFFICER

Commander, we've taken damage to port
(MORE)

CADET OFFICER (CONT'D)
sections! Hull integrity holding, but
we're venting atmosphere from
secondary systems.

BELLE
(steady, despite the crisis)
Engineering seal the breach. Continue
forward thrust. We're almost in
position.

Her eyes flicker blue as she sees Minardi's transmission.

MINARDI
(message to crew)
All stations, Protocol 717, Execute.

Belle's hands move swiftly over her console.

BELLE
(to herself)
Initiating monitor malfunction... now.

The bridge displays flicker and distort, showing false
readings as the shuttle bay operations disappear from view.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SHUTTLE BAY AREA - CONTINUOUS

In the chaos of asteroid debris and flack explosions, two
small shuttles emerge from their respective ships. JACE
pilots the Huntsman's shuttle while NISO handles the sleek
Mark VIII. They execute a perfect rendezvous, swapping
positions in the shadow of a massive asteroid.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

MINARDI
(watching the tactical display as
both shuttles successfully dock
in their new bays)
All stations, the Pardosa is
attempting to break through our
defensive line. Weapons, target their
engines -- disable, don't destroy.

The crew follows orders, their weapons fire carefully
calculated.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE - CONTINUOUS

The Huntsman emerges from the asteroid field first, its hull

scuffed but intact. The Pardosa follows, visibly damaged but operational, trailing vapor from its hull breach.

INT. MONITORING SHIP - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

ADMIRAL HAYES (50s) watches the display with satisfaction.

ADMIRAL HAYES
Excellent tactical display. The
Huntsman's victory should play well
with the public.

OFFICER
Sir, both ships experienced monitoring
system malfunctions during the deep
asteroid phase. We lost telemetry for
approximately three minutes.

ADMIRAL HAYES
(dismissive)
Asteroid interference. Common in dense
fields. The important thing is the
outcome.

EXT. ASTEROID BELT - SPACE - CONTINUOUS

The Huntsman assumes formation with the monitoring ships. In its shuttle bay, the Mark VIII sits quietly -- mission accomplished.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

MINARDI
(to crew)
Outstanding work, everyone. Mission
objectives achieved.

He exchanges a subtle glance with Sullivan, who nods slightly.

MINARDI (CONT'D)
(into comm)
Admiral Redback, simulation complete.
The Huntsman stands ready for
departure.

REDBACK (V.O.)
(into comm)
Congratulations, Captain. You've given
the public quite a show. See you back
at the station.

As the ships form up for return, Minardi allows himself a small smile. The heist is complete, and in two days, they'll embark on humanity's greatest adventure -- with the tools they need to succeed.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - DOCKING BAY 7 - NIGHT BEFORE DEPARTURE

The station hums with pre-departure tension. Mara stands before the Huntsman's entry door, hands clenched. Two SECURITY GUARDS block the way.

GUARD 1

(flatly)

No one's allowed on board until morning, ma'am. Admiral's orders.

MARA

(steady but desperate)

I'm Mara, part of the crew. Just need to grab some belongings -- won't take a minute.

The guards exchange a glance. Guard 1 taps his comm.

GUARD 1

(into comm)

Security to Captain Minardi.

Mara's face pales -- this is the last thing she wanted.

CUT TO:

INT. BELLE AND MINARDI'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

MINARDI sits with BELLE, sharing a quiet meal amid holographic star maps. The air is thick with unspoken goodbyes. His fork pauses as the comm crackles.

MINARDI

(INTO COMM)

Go ahead, Security

GUARD 1 (V.O.)

Sorry to disturb you, Captain.
Lieutenant Mara says she needs to
board The Huntsman to collect some
(MORE)

GUARD 1 (V.O.) (CONT'D)
belongings.

Minardi's eyes meet Belle's -- hers soft, knowing. He knows Mara seeks ghosts, not belongings.

MINARDI
(into comm, after a beat)
Permission granted.

BACK TO:

INT. HUNTSMAN CORRIDOR - NIGHT

The doors hiss open. Mara steps inside, the ship's interior glowing with a warm hum. She moves toward the core console.

MARA
(to the air, voice low)
Horus, I need confidentiality on this discussion. No logs, no records.

HORUS
(AI voice, calm)
Understood, Mara. This discussion is confidential. What do you need?

MARA
(voice cracking)
Show me the holographic replay of The Battle of Heplar Belt, date 110-20-15. I want everything -- footage, crew actions, audio -- all of it.

HORUS
Due to confidentiality and data protection protocols, mission details require Captain's authorization. (a beat) Fortunately, Captain Minardi has just lifted that requirement. Accessing records for The Battle of Heplar Belt, dated 110-20-15.

Mara nods, surprised by Minardi's trust.

The holographic display materializes. Three enemy ships lurk in asteroid shadows. The HUNTSMAN appears, unsuspecting, then chaos erupts as lasers streak across the void.

The holographic replay shows the battle's intensity: crew voices crackling over comms, the Huntsman's retaliation

destroying one ship (Mara's mother's), crippling another, before taking critical hits. A second Huntsman-class vessel swoops in, scattering the remaining attacker.

As the hologram fades, Mara stands frozen, tears glistening. The truth hits her -- the Huntsman was ambushed, not the aggressor.

HORUS(V.O.)

During that battle, the Huntsman lost
three crew members.

Mara exhales, a tear tracing her scar. Her fists unclench, feeling a shift.

The bridge door slides open. CHIEF ENGINEER SULLIVAN (58, gruff) steps in.

MARA

(startled)

Chief Sullivan... I didn't know
anybody else was here.

SULLIVAN

(leaning against doorframe)

I've lived on the Huntsman ever since
that day. She's my home now.

MARA

(confused, softening)

How come?

Sullivan gestures for her to sit. She hesitates, then takes a seat. He settles beside her, expression reflective.

SULLIVAN

My wife and I met at training school
-- finest engineer I ever worked with.
When we got ambushed that day, I was
in the toilet, taking a leak. By the
time I got back to engineering, she'd
locked herself inside. Reactor breach,
radiation off the charts. She kept
going -- fought for five minutes,
patched the ship, sealed the breach...
then she was gone. Never got to say
goodbye.

Mara's throat tightens, remembering Horus's words about the crew members who died.

MARA
(barely a whisper)
I don't know what to say...

SULLIVAN
(raising hand, distant with pain)
That's why I'm still here, carrying on
her work. She's still part of the ship
-- that's why I call this old boat
'the wife.' Anyway, I've got to get
back to work. I hope you found what
you're looking for.

He stands, pausing at the door.

SULLIVAN (CONT'D)
So I guess I'll be seeing you in the
morning?

MARA
(quiet but genuine)
Yes, you will... and thank you,
Sullie.

He smiles briefly, warmth breaking through his gruff
exterior, before leaving. Mara sits alone, the weight of the
past settling around her like shadows.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - MAIN PIAZZA - DEPARTURE DAY

The massive central piazza thrums with energy. Thousands of
CITIZENS pack the viewing areas, enormous holographic
displays broadcasting the ceremony across the station.

GRAND SENATOR SICARIUS appears on the monitors, his voice
resonating through speakers.

GRAND SENATOR SICARIUS
Citizens of Unity and Serenity. We
find ourselves at a pivotal moment in
our history. (a beat) We are on the
cusp of first contact with beings from
a distant future. At the heart of this
extraordinary event is Commander
Belle, whose own journey has
unwittingly become the bridge to these
future beings.

The cameras find BELLE in the crowd, her eyes flickering with faint blue light. She stands beside MINARDI, their hands clasped.

GRAND SENATOR SICARIUS (CONT'D)

Today, we entrust the crew of The Huntsman with a mission of great significance. They will venture into the unknown, into the future, to help our newfound friends. (voice building)
To the crew of The Huntsman: you carry the spirit of our civilization. May your journey herald a new era of understanding across time and space.
Peace and goodwill to you all.

The crowd ERUPTS in cheers. Confetti streams from the upper levels.

The crew begins their walk across the piazza. Children wave flags, adults reach out, veterans salute with tears in their eyes.

BELLE pauses, her crystalline-enhanced perception showing her the crowd in stunning detail. She raises her hand in a gentle wave.

MINARDI takes her other hand, steadying her. Together, they lead their crew toward the exit.

INT. GATEWAY STAR STATION 11 - CORRIDOR TO DOCKING BAY -
CONTINUOUS

The vibrant noise of the piazza fades as they enter a stark, silent corridor. The contrast is profound -- from celebration to solitude in a matter of steps.

The crew walks in silence, their shared resolve speaking volumes.

EXT. THE HUNTSMAN - DOCKING BAY 7 - CONTINUOUS

The Huntsman sits in its berth, chrome hull gleaming under the bay lights. Two STATION OFFICERS stand at attention, saluting as the crew approaches.

LIEUTENANT MARTINEZ

(formal but warm)

Good luck, Captain, Commander.

MINARDI
(returning the salute)
Thank you, Lieutenant.

The crew pauses at the boarding ramp. MINARDI and BELLE exchange a look -- a silent conversation of reassurance.

One by one, they board. SULLIVAN places his hand on the hull, whispering something inaudible. MARA looks back once, then steps forward with new purpose. The twins move as one, while TANNER guides JACE aboard.

BELLE is last. She turns for one final look at the station, then steps inside.

The boarding ramp retracts with a smooth mechanical whisper.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The crew takes their stations with practiced efficiency. The bridge hums to life.

MINARDI Prepare for departure. Take us out.

MILO Undocking sequence initiated.

EXT. SPACE - THE CELESTIAL - CONTINUOUS

The visitor's ship awaits -- a silent sentinel from the future. Ten times larger than the Huntsman, its exterior curves like fluid water, with an undulating surface that ripples. The hull, coated in shimmering material, plays with starlight, appearing almost transparent against space's backdrop.

As the Huntsman approaches, the Celestial awakens. Its hull reshapes with fluid grace, petals unfurling to create a perfect docking berth.

EXT. SPACE - THE DOCKING - CONTINUOUS

The Huntsman aligns with the opening -- a fusion of time and technology, an embrace extending across millennia.

INT. THE HUNTSMAN - BRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The crew watches in awe as their ship is drawn into the Celestial's embrace.

MINARDI
(to his crew)
Whatever comes next, we face it
together.

EXT. SPACE - THE CELESTIAL - CONTINUOUS

The Huntsman disappears into the organic docking bay. The opening seals behind them, the hull returning to its original form.

As the Celestial draws nearer to the Gateway portal, a luminous azure glow emerges, painting the edges with bright, neon light. This ethereal radiance signals the portal's awakening. In an instant, the space within the portal shifts into a shimmering golden expanse. This spectral transformation marks the portal's activation, a doorway to the distant future, now wide open.

With a flash of light that illuminates nearby asteroids, the ship vanishes.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END